

HIGH TURNOUT IN T.N.
Bypolls held for one LS seat, 5 Assembly seats
NEWS » PAGE 4

TUMULTUOUS CAREER
Bestselling British novelist Jeffrey Archer dies at 86
WORLD » PAGE 14

OPERATION RESHUFFLE
Govt. intervenes in Mumbai airport row
BUSINESS » PAGE 12

OPENING UP
Indian research can shape world
National laboratories need to be liberated from insularity
OPINION » PAGE 9

SMRITI TAKES OVER
Harmanpreet quits as India captain
SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



Houthis deny any setbacks, claim attack on Riyadh

SANAA
Yemen's Houthis on Tuesday denied being pushed back by government forces, who have launched a major operation to recapture lost territory and claimed to have retaken certain areas. The group also claimed an attack on the Saudi Arabian capital's main airport on Monday night. » PAGE 14

Privilege vs free speech case ends after 20 years

NEW DELHI
After 20 years, the Supreme Court on Tuesday disposed of as infructuous a reference related to questions linked to legislative privilege being used to choke free speech, arising out of a 2003 Tamil Nadu Assembly resolution to arrest editors of *The Hindu* for an editorial criticising then Chief Minister Jayalalithaa. » PAGE 4

First indigenous fleet support ship launched

VISAKHAPATNAM
Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh launched the Navy's first indigenous Fleet Support Ship, named Surya, and laid the keel for the fifth vessel of the series, FSS-5, at Hindustan Shipyard Limited in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday. He urged Indian shipyards to look beyond self-reliance towards global competitiveness. » PAGE 3

Rahul calls SIR 'treason' as INDIA unites against ECI; MPs detained

LoP leads sit-in at Akashvani Bhawan after protest march to ECI headquarters stopped; PM Modi 'stole votes to hijack the country', he says; Opposition leaders demand CEC's removal, suspension of SIR, and restoration of deleted names in rolls

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

“What has been done to my country is treason,” Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, said on Tuesday even as the Opposition parties closed ranks, marching from Parliament to the Election Commission of India's (ECI) headquarters to demand the scrapping of special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, restoration of the names deleted from the rolls, and sacking of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Later in the evening, Mr. Gandhi, his sister - Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and other MPs were forcibly removed, detained and huddled into a bus even as Mr. Gandhi resisted, attempting to wriggle out of the vehicle's window.

Before being detained, Mr. Gandhi, along with Ms. Vadra and Congress leader K.C. Venugopal, held a sit-in at Akashvani Bhavan, just a few metres from Nirvachan Sadan, where the protest march was stopped at 11 a.m. by Delhi Police.

Around 6 p.m., the Congress reached out to all parties to join the sit-in. Trinamool Congress's Derek O' Brien and Mahua Moitra, Indian Union Muslim League (IUML)'s E.T. Muhammad Basheer, and Samajwadi Party (SP)'s Mohibullah Nadevi, who were removed earlier in the day by the police, returned to



Rally call: Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on barricades during the INDIA bloc-led protest march, demanding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation, in New Delhi on Tuesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

join Mr. Gandhi.

While the Aam Aadmi Party and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam stayed away from the protest, all 19 parties that attended the September 30 Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) meeting were represented at the sit-in. Top Opposition leaders, including SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, Trinamool general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, Shiv Sena (UBT)'s Sanjay Raut, and Nationalist Congress Party (SP)'s Supriya Sule, were seen walking together.

For the first time, Biju Janata Dal, which maintains a distance from both the ruling side and the IN-

DIA bloc, joined in.

Mr. Yadav accused the ECI of working for the BJP. “Only BJP members can vote. BJP's workers can be India's citizens,” he said, accusing the government of using multiple measures to “steal the mandate”. He accused the ECI of especially targeting the “Pichde, Dalit and Alapsankhyak (PDA)” (backward, Dalit and minorities).

Mr. Banerjee was seen raising slogans while standing beside Mr. Gandhi.

The march began at 10.30 a.m. from Makar Dwar of Parliament, with the leaders carrying a banner reading: “Election

Commission is compromised – Sack Gyanesh Kumar”.

Slogans such as “vote chor gaddi chodh” (vote thief leave the seat), “Gyanesh Kumar istifa do” (Gyanesh Kumar resign) were raised, and leaders were seen carrying placards reading “BJP hi CEC hai” and “Democracy not for sale”.

The detained Parliamentarians were taken to Kingsway Camp police station. They were released later at 10:15 pm. The INDIA bloc will hold another protest on Wednesday.

MORE REPORTS
» PAGE 5

Could not accept 'unusual demand' for meet outside premises: ECI

NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) said on Tuesday that INDIA bloc parties had demanded a meeting with the full commission at a venue outside its premises which was “unusual” and therefore “could not be accepted”. The ECI said that it had proposed that its senior-most officer on duty could be sent to the meeting venue, adding that this “unprecedented” offer was also declined by the protesting leaders. » PAGE 5

Pioneer of IceCube neutrino detector wins physics Nobel

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

This year's Nobel Prize in Physics will be awarded to Belgium-born Francis Halzen, 82, for his contributions to IceCube, a neutrino observatory in the South Pole, and for the discovery of high-energy neutrinos of astrophysical origin.

While there are several massive detectors for these extremely elusive particles, IceCube is designed to find high-energy neutrinos that are believed to have originated far in space from energetic collisions. These “cosmic neutrinos” with extremely high energies are very rare and an enormous volume of ice is needed to observe an adequate number of collisions.

Mr. Halzen, who is presently at the University of Wisconsin-Madison in the U.S., first presented his vision for capturing neutrinos at the South Pole in 1988. Pure, undisturbed ice is an ideal medium to capture these neutrinos: when they occasionally collide with atomic nuclei, they produce charged particles that announce themselves as a flash of pale blue light.

The South Pole's ice has many advantages, as it is free from various types of interference and the area is geologically stable. Mr. Halzen's idea caught on and, just a few years later, preliminary testing was conducted on sensors in ice. IceCube covers an entire cubic kilometre (or about 917 million litres of water) and was completed in 2010. It has 5,160 optical sensors to detect the Che-



Francis Halzen

renkov light produced by neutrino interactions, with its principal scientific focus on higher-energy astrophysical neutrinos.

The Cherenkov light is the blue flash produced when a charged particle travels through a transparent medium faster than light can travel through that medium. Researchers reported the first high-energy cosmic neutrinos in 2013 and, in 2018, traced one such neutrino to a distant blazar, a galaxy with a supermassive black hole at its centre that fires a jet of particles and radiation almost directly towards earth.

“Francis Halzen has led an international team of researchers and engineers who have provided us with a fantastic instrument. His tenacity and scientific vision has paved the way for a new kind of astronomy,” Mark Pearce, Chair of the Nobel Committee for Physics, said. The neutrino interactions that are continuously collected by IceCube will provide researchers with knowledge about the violent settings in which high-energy neutrinos can be created – and could even reveal previously unknown cosmic phenomena, a statement added.

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8

Centre plans five-pronged reforms as GST Council meets tomorrow

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Centre will propose a five-pronged plan for the next set of reforms to the Goods and Services Tax (GST) system at the upcoming GST Council meeting on Thursday, according to sources in the Union Finance Ministry.

These reforms are aimed at automating and easing a lot of the current administrative bottlenecks in the GST system, and reducing the compliance burden, especially for small businesses. Rates, including the GST on the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, will not be on the agenda.

The proposal covers process reforms, structural reforms, ease of living and doing business, exports of services, and e-commerce.

Some of the key changes proposed involve automatic invoice matching between buyers and sellers, reducing paperwork

Reform proposal

The five-pronged plan aims at automating and easing administrative bottlenecks in the GST system

FOCUS ON:

- Process reforms
- Structural reforms
- Ease of living and doing business
- Export of services
- E-commerce

- Key beneficiaries will be small businesses, inter-State businesses, and service exporters
- The proposals will be discussed at the GST Council meeting and, if approved, will be implemented in a staggered manner



around claiming input tax credits (ITC), reducing the number of times small taxpayers have to file returns, and removing multi-State registrations for small businesses looking to sell across the country.

Relief measures

The Centre will share a concept note with States on allowing small taxpayers who supply only to consumers to file their returns once a year instead of once a month as is currently the case.

At the moment, provid-

ing a service to a foreign client through a branch abroad is not counted as export of service. The Centre will propose to amend this to categorise such businesses as export.

At the moment, 61% of taxpayers receive their GST registration within three working days without the need for a tax officer's involvement, an official in the Union Finance Ministry said. The Centre will now propose a streamlining of processes for the remaining taxpayers so as to avoid “unnecessary qu-

eries” and rejections.

Further, the Centre will propose an upgrade to the existing invoice management system to match invoices in such a manner that corrections and changes made to an invoice by the seller are recorded at each step and automatically reflected in the buyer's invoice.

“This would avoid a large number of notices issued to taxpayers due to invoice mismatches,” the official explained.

At the moment, businesses complain that their input tax credits are often held up because their suppliers have not filed their returns. The Centre is now trying to address this issue.

Further, the Centre will propose that ordinary business costs, that currently do not get refunded as ITC, should be brought into the ITC system. In addition, taxes paid on input services, earlier not eligible for ITC, will be proposed to be made eligible.

Spy racket sharing data with Pakistan busted; 13 Navy staffers under scanner

Rajulapudi Srinivas
VIJAYAWADA

An espionage racket involving 18 people, including 13 personnel working for the Navy, allegedly shared sensitive information with Pakistani operatives, according to intelligence officials from Andhra Pradesh. Two of the accused have been arrested.

Officials said on Tuesday that the Counter Intelligence Cell (CIC) of the Andhra Pradesh Intelligence Department uncovered the racket, which allegedly shared information related to defence establishments, including strategic locations at the Visakhapatnam Naval Base and other parts of the country, with Pakistani intelligence operatives.

Acting on a tip-off, the counter-intelligence police in Vijayawada registered a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Official Secrets Act, and sections of the Bharati-



Annam Sai Vara Prasad Pradeep Mukherjee

ya Nyaya Sanhita, including Section 61(2) (criminal conspiracy).

Under ‘Operation Firewall-2026’, 12 CIC teams were deployed to Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Goa, Delhi, Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, Bihar and Chhattisgarh. The teams, in coordination with Navy officers, anti-terrorist squads, and the local police, conducted searches, examined the complicity of the 18 suspects, and seized electronic equipment from them.

Annam Sai Vara Prasad, a contract driver engaged for Naval officers, was picked up in Visakhapatnam. He is accused of having shared key information related to the Naval Base in return for money.

The A.P. counter-intelligence police arrested a civilian driver and a Visakhapatnam Naval Base employee

Another accused, Pradeep Mukherjee, a Naval employee at the Visakhapatnam Naval Base, was arrested in Coimbatore. He is accused of having shared an OTP for the activation of a WhatsApp account for a Pakistani intelligence operative and of having passed on sensitive information relating to defence establishments.

Both men were produced in court on Monday, after which they were sent to Visakhapatnam Jail under judicial custody until October 14.

Pakistani operatives

According to investigators, it is suspected that women intelligence operatives from Pakistan approached the accused using fake pro-

files on social media sites.

A source said, “The alleged approach involved false professional identities, misleading promises, sexually explicit content, and monetary inducements intended to draw personnel into sharing sensitive defence information. The information sought reportedly included the movement and number of Naval ships and submarines, photographs and videos of Naval assets, and sensitive establishments, photographs and details of Commanding Officers. The material also describes attempts to persuade personnel to show sensitive areas of Naval establishments, ships and submarines during video calls.”

The material seized during searches allegedly exposed a financial arrangement in which funds originating from Pakistan were routed through cryptocurrency channels and traders or other intermediaries to persons drawn into the network.

A IN-Y

INBRIEF



4 students injured in clash over Vande Mataram event

Four students were reportedly injured in clashes between the police and student protesters at the Central University of Kerala (CUK) in Kasaragod where various student organisations were protesting against a national seminar on *Vande Mataram* on Tuesday. The scuffle broke out as members of the SFI, NSUI, MSF and the AISF tried to enter the seminar hall, alleging that the event was an attempt to “advance a saffronisation agenda” at the university.

Man gets 47-year jail term for sexually assaulting minor

A special court in Kerala on Tuesday sentenced a 43-year-old man to 47 years of rigorous imprisonment for sexually assaulting a 15-year-old boy, who is his relative and neighbour. Special Judge Anju Meera Birla of the Thiruvananthapuram Fast Track Special Court also slapped a fine of ₹32,000 on the convict. The court said that he must undergo an additional three years and three months of imprisonment if he fails to pay the fine.

Karnataka to launch drive to close defunct borewells

Karnataka will launch a Statewide campaign to identify and close defunct and unsafe open borewells, Minor Irrigation Minister Ajay Dharam Singh said in Bengaluru on Tuesday. The ‘Borewell Suraksha Abhiyan’ will initially focus on defunct borewells coming under the Minor Irrigation Department. It will later cover borewells under other departments and those in public places. “Not a single borewell should become a threat to a child’s life,” he said.

UDF govt. is implementing BJP agenda in Keralam, says Pinarayi

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly and CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan has accused the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government in the State of implementing the agenda of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its political arm, the BJP. He was delivering a speech to inaugurate the two-day extended Kozhikode district committee meeting of the party in Kozhikode on Tuesday.

‘Subservience’
Mr. Vijayan said that the latest example of the UDF government’s “subservience” to the RSS-BJP combine was its decision to weaken the State Planning Board. He claimed that the task of preparing various projects under the five-year plan had been given to private agencies. “The BJP government disbanded the National Planning Commission and introduced NITI Aayog. Similarly, by roping in private consultancy firms, the State government has made the Planning Board just a figurehead,” he said. The government’s “soft approach” towards the RSS agenda was evident in its subservience in the PM-SHRI controversy, the singing of the National Song *Vande Mataram* in full at public events, and the alleged bid to “saffronise” State universities, he said. Another issue was the government’s decision to implement the Centre’s “anti-employee” Labour Codes, he pointed out.

Surya, India’ first indigenous fleet support ship, launched

It is a floating supply powerhouse that can sustain protracted, high-intensity naval engagements; Rajnath urges Indian shipyards to look beyond self-reliance and aim at international markets

V. Kamalakara Rao
VISAKHAPATNAM

Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh launched the Navy’s first indigenous fleet support ship (FSS-1), named *Surya*, and laid the keel for the fifth vessel of the series, FSS-5, at Hindustan Shipyard Limited (HSL) in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday.

The ceremony was attended by Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary (Defence Production) Sanjeev Kumar, Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Eastern Naval Command



Homemade vessel: Rajnath Singh speaking at the launch of the fleet support ship, *Surya*, in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday. V. RAJU

Vice Admiral Sanjay Bhalla, HSL CMD Rear Admiral C. Raghuram, and other dignitaries. The Minister urged Indian shipyards to look beyond self-reliance towards global competitiveness, aiming to serve inter-

national markets, build a presence in marine technology, and provide advanced ship repair services. The massive Fleet Support Ship (FSS) initiative is backed by a landmark ₹19,000-crore contract

3.7 lakh SIR notices pending in Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

With hearings on notices issued under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) scheduled to conclude by October 12, more than 3.70 lakh of the 6.66 lakh notices pending Statewide for hearing are in Bengaluru, Shilpa Nag C.T., Special Commissioner (Election), said while addressing the media on Tuesday. Of the more than 24

lakh notices issued in Bengaluru for logical discrepancies and for being unmapped, only 13,550 notices are yet to be delivered. Booth-level officers will visit houses and collect documents, while hearings will be conducted online only in some cases. Ms. Nag said 1,117 Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs) have been appointed to conduct hearings, in addition to the 76 regular AEROs.

Form 7 filings linked to BJP, says Owaisi

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi on Tuesday alleged that numerous pre-filled Form 7 applications seeking deletion of voters’ names from the electoral rolls were submitted in the Goshamahahal Assembly constituency, and sought action against the individual who submitted the forms in bulk. Goshamahahal is part of

the Hyderabad Lok Sabha seat. Citing a specific example, Mr. Owaisi said 122 Form 7 applications had been submitted at Booth 28 in Goshamahahal. He said it was part of a deliberate move to remove voters belonging to a minority community. Noting that the forms were “pre-printed”, he said his enquiries revealed that the person who submitted them was one Janardhan, a “BJP supporter or sympathiser”.

TVK-led regime has backstabbed nurses, says Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Tuesday alleged that the TVK-led government had backstabbed nurses after promising them that it would fulfil their demands.

In a social media message, he condemned the arrest (on the night of October 5) of nurses who had been fighting for job security, equal pay, and permanent employment. “How could the government bring itself to arrest nurses when it is not able to hold talks with them? The legal adviser of the nurses has alleged that they were arrested after being invited for talks,” he said.

Mr. Stalin said the TVK had supported the protesters before assuming office, but had taken police action against them after coming to power. “What do the TVK Ministers say about this incident when they have been defending Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay? The nurses continued their protest with the help of the flashlight on their mobile phones after the power supply was cut. They were arrested overnight. Is this the change the TVK is talking about,” he asked.

The former Chief Minister also recalled the warning given by a police officer, who was seen gesticulating with her fingers, saying, “Your life is important”. “Will the Chief Minister, who holds the police portfolio, respond to it? Or will he make reels

Nurses had been fighting for job security, equal pay, and permanent employment

on the woman police officer’s action and advertise it as an achievement?” he said.

Height of cruelty: EPS
AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said the “police brutality” unleashed by the TVK-led government on the nurses, who were staging a peaceful protest, “is the height of cruelty”.

“The police force under the Chief Minister has committed this fascist atrocity against nurses who are engaged in the vital duty of saving lives. How will this ‘Reels Chief Minister’ justify it?” he said in a social media post.

“Before coming to power, do you remember what your party functionaries – and those who are Ministers today – said, standing in front of these nurses? Is this the change you promised: saying one thing before coming to power and doing the exact opposite after assuming office,” he asked.

He urged the government to immediately release the arrested nurses and ensure that no cases were filed against them. AMMK general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran also criticised the government for the “arbitrary action” against the nurses.

Field visit



People gather near a training aircraft that made an emergency landing in a field near the Kalaburagi airport, Karnataka, on Tuesday owing to a snag. No one was injured. Two pilots were aboard the aircraft attached to the Redbird Flight Training Academy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Not getting work at Dandiya events, say Muslim bouncers

Serish Nanisetty
HYDERABAD

A collective of bouncers in Hyderabad has raised alarm over discrimination and denial of job opportunities to Muslims for the Dandiya events during the nine-day Navratri festival season.

“Earlier, we used to get contracts for most of the Dandiya events across the city. This year, most of my colleagues have been told that Muslims are no longer welcome to work as bouncers. My team has 10 members and some of them are not Muslims; how will I pay them now,” asked Mohammed Feroz who is part of the 200-member collective of bouncers.

‘Hyderabad was never like this. It’s strange. We have what is called the Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb’

“Our work involves crowd management and safety. The only things required for this line of work is personality, good physique and experience. We don’t even enter the venue for anything or interact with the guests,” he said.

Worrying turn
“Hyderabad was never like this. We have what is called the *Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb* (syncretic culture). This is strange,” Mr. Feroz said.

“The bookings start at least a month before the Dandiya events in Hyderabad. There are thousands of events that are lined up but now many of the organisers are saying we don’t want Muslim bouncers. It is not fair to harm someone’s livelihood like this,” said Salige Prabhakar, who has been in this line of work for the past 10 years.

“This discrimination began in a small way in 2024 but now they are openly saying ‘no Muslims,’” said Mr. Prabhakar. Mr. Feroz appealed to the government and the Chief Minister as well as the police officials to step in and end the discrimination.

Panel revamp widens rift in Keralam film artistes’ grouping

G. Krishnakumar
KOCHI

The rift within the Association of Malayalam Movie Artistes (AMMA) has widened following a recent decision by the executive committee to fill the vacant posts of vice-presidents, treasurer and joint secretary. Actors Asha Aravind and Sijoy Varghese were made vice-presidents by the committee in a revamp held last week after the actors’ body plunged into organisational turmoil following the general body meeting held here on June 21. Actors Neena Kurup and Sarayu Mohan were elected treasurer and joint secretary, respectively.



AMMA’s executive committee filled a few vacancies recently.

The 17-member panel, led by its first woman president Shweta Menon, had announced its resignation at the general body meeting after a section of the association moved a no-confidence motion against the leadership. She later retracted her decision, and the panel continued to hold their positions after the Ernakulam Munsiff Court stayed the decision

taken at the general body meeting to form an ad hoc panel. Actor Ansiba Hassan, who stepped down from the panel in February after accusing actor Tini Tom and a section of the members of subjecting her to character assassination and making communal remarks, questioned the legality of the new appointments, stating they were made by a panel that had announced its decision to step down. “The general body, the highest decision-making unit in the association, had also approved their decision,” she said. The panel has said that the appointments were carried out in line with the by-laws of the association.

Act against illegal resorts in Karnataka tiger reserves: Minister to forest officials

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Environment Minister Ramalinga Reddy has directed forest officials to take immediate action against all illegally established resorts and homestays in the eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) and buffer zone of various tiger reserves and protected areas of Karnataka. Mr. Reddy, who chaired a meeting of the Standing Committee of the State Board for Wildlife, sought details on the number of resorts, homestays and other commercial activities in the ESZ and buffer zone after the ESZ was notified for various tiger reserves and protected areas.



The Minister has sought details on the number of homestays, resorts and commercial activities in the eco-sensitive zone.

He also directed that there should be minimal disturbance in ESZ areas and that they should be declared as silent zones. He also sought preparation for Zonal Master Plans to create awareness among

people on the dos and don’ts in ESZ areas.

No quarrying
A proposal for allowing quarrying activities in the ESZ of Kappatagudda Wildlife Sanctuary in Gadag

was rejected. The proposals for electrification BSNL saturation towers, OFC cables and a small connecting bridge were approved for recommendation to the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC NBWL). At the meeting, it was also decided to submit a proposal to the SC NBWL for rationalisation of the boundary of the Shettihalli Wildlife Sanctuary where the boundary was not properly demarcated while notifying it. The Standing Committee of the State Board for Wildlife also decided not to alter the eco-sensitive zone of the Bannerughatta National Park.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari vacated one seat to retain another, bypolls were needed seat Nandigram seat. RITU RAJ KONWAR

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The latest contract marks another step towards increasing the indigenous content of critical weapon systems and reducing dependence on foreign sources for advanced military equipment.

SCIENCE

In this Delhi studio, tintype brings chemistry into every portrait

Tintype is a traditional, hand-made photographic process from the mid-19th century that made portrait photography more accessible outside the formal and expensive studios of the time; it seems simple yet it conceals a process that demands scientific precision — and therein lies its charm

Aditya Ansh
NEW DELHI

In an age when a portrait can be made in a fraction of a second, Vibhav Kapoor, artist and assistant professor at O.P. Jindal Global University, Sonipat, spends several minutes making one photograph, much of the time spent negotiating with chemistry.

In his Delhi-NCR studio, Mr. Kapoor works with tintype, a 19th-century photographic process in which an image is created directly on a metal plate.

The French photographer Adolphe Alexandre Martin is credited with developing the technique in 1853, two years after Frederick Scott Archer invented the wet-plate collodion process.

Chemically demanding

Unlike processes that produced glass negatives or paper prints, tintypes created a positive image directly on a dark metal plate.

Mr. Kapoor takes a plate with collodion, a syrupy solution of nitrocellulose dissolved in ether and alcohol. He pours it onto a metal plate to form a thin, sticky film, and sensitises it in a silver-nitrate bath in which the iodides and bromides react with silver nitrate to form light-sensitive silver iodide and silver bromide.

Finally, he exposes these light-sensitive compounds through a large-format camera, and develops the images in a dark room using a ferrous sulphate solution acidified with glacial acetic acid and thinned with alcohol; it amplifies the latent image by converting more exposed silver halides into visible metallic silver.

The entire sequence from coating to fixing must be completed while the plate remains wet. There is also no negative to reprint from, so duplicating tintypes is equally arduous.

19th century process

In the mid-19th century, the tintype process was valued for being relatively inexpensive and durable. The dominant photographic process of the era was the daguerreotype. It was costly because it required silver-plated copper sheets as the base material plus iodine and mercury vapour to develop images. Together with the labour-intensive crafting process, each daguerreotype was a luxury item.

Tintypes, however, afforded portraits outside the more formal, expensive photographic studios of the period. In India as well, the process formed part of the early history of photography.

In 1864, a British photographer named T. Murray introduced Sawai Ram Singh II



A tintype of Padmanabh Singh, of the erstwhile ruling dynasty of Jaipur State; (Below) portrait in tintype. VIBHAV KAPOOR/SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



of Jaipur to the tintype camera and documented his court, architecture, and lives of women in the royal zenana. Murray is also known to have helped the ruler develop a royal archive of visuals.

According to Mr. Kapoor, the Jaipur royal photographer Ram Singh also used the process. “It is a very traditional, hand-made process,” Mr. Kapoor said. But its apparent simplicity conceals a process that demands scientific precision.

Mr. Kapoor first learnt tintype photography during his master’s degree at the Rochester Institute of Technology, New York, which he spent coating plates, photographing, developing, drying, and finally varnishing the finished image.

The way tintype works also affects the photographer and the subject. The CMOS sensors in today’s digital cameras are so fast that a person needs to pose for just a second. On the other hand, the light-sensitive compounds in tintype photography ‘record’ the light over 8-10 seconds, so the subjects need to present themselves still for that period.

For a portrait, as Mr. Kapoor put it,

“The person is performing ..., presenting themselves.”

The image emerges in 10 to 15 minutes thereafter.

Weather and chemistry

That said, the photograph’s most unpredictable component is the weather. “The chemistry is very volatile and humidity plays a crucial role,” Mr. Kapoor said.

“During the monsoon, the humidity causes the tintypes to develop spots,” Matthew Fossier, a U.S. tintype practitioner in Texas, said.

Dust is another serious problem. As dust particles settle on the wet collodion layer, they interrupt the formation of silver halide crystals. When the plate is developed, the affected area produces metallic silver differently from the surrounding film, and which appears as an opaque or transparent spot.

Temperature fluctuations can create other artefacts as well, per Mr. Fossier. The collodion contains volatile solvents and heat makes them evaporate faster, leaving the film to become sticky. The plate must be moved quickly to the silver-nitrate bath, where silver ions react with the halides in the collodion to form the light-sensitive silver-halide layer. If the collodion has begun to set unevenly by

then, however, the resulting layer can be uneven as well.

He added that the effect is pronounced when pouring the collodion, which reduces the time available to get the plate into the silver bath.

According to Mr. Kapoor, the Delhi-NCR temperatures require him to adjust his solutions: “Heat acts as a catalyst [and] more heat means reactions are faster. The developer has to be managed.”

The developer is a chemical solution that reveals the image captured on a sensitised metal plate after exposure. But in warmer weather, the developer works faster, causing streaks or an uneven fog to appear in the picture.

To avoid this, Mr. Kapoor dilutes the developer to change its strength and how long it stays on the plate, slowing the reaction, and allowing the picture to develop clearly.

Photography arrived in India in the 19th century, and the wet-collodion processes became ubiquitous as tintypes circulated in Indian towns in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Today, however, Mr. Kapoor said “only a handful of photographers in India practise tintype”. (Aditya Ansh is an independent media writer based in New Delhi. adityaansh30@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Tintype created images directly on metal plates; it was developed by French photographer Adolphe Alexandre Martin in 1853, two years after Frederick Scott Archer invented the wet-plate collodion process

The process was popular because it was cheap and durable unlike the more expensive daguerreotype; it made portrait photography accessible to more people outside formal studios

Tintypes became common in towns across the country during the late 19th and early 20th centuries; today, however, only a few photographers in India still practise the process

BIG SHOT



A drone view shows tourists swimming in green seawater associated with a plankton bloom, in Koh Lan, Pattaya, Chonburi province, Thailand. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Silk Road: Eurasia’s web of trade



Cultural crossroad: The main routes of the Silk Road. KELVIN CASE (CC BY-SA)

Vasudevan Mukunth

Contrary to the name, the Silk Road was a network of multiple land and maritime trade routes connecting parts of east, central, south, and west Asia. The network took different shapes over more than a millennium but became especially important from around the second century BC, when China’s Han dynasty expanded west and established contacts with Central Asian states. Because Chinese silk was a prized commodity then, the network was called the Silk Road. Since it offered well-travelled roads, the Silk Road also became the routes that technologies, religions, artistic styles, languages, and natural philosophy took to spread across Eurasia. It is in fact how papermaking spread out from China, as did how Buddhism travelled from India through Central Asia into China. Christianity, Manichaeism, and later Islam also

spread along parts of the network — just like musical traditions, and astrological and medical knowledge.

The network also benefited from the Mongol Empire bringing much of Eurasia within a connected political system in the 13th and 14th centuries, and encouraged long-distance journeys. The Road’s import gradually declined by the early modern period as trade became cheaper over sea routes, especially in the Indian Ocean, while political conditions changed on land. Even so, the network proved instrumental to make premodern Eurasia as economically and culturally interconnected as it had become, despite its size.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Break the chain

India must focus on cutting transmission of leprosy

CM
YK

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

should be able to register without hurdles. Transparency in the Election Commission is essential to restoring public trust.

Sankalp Gupta,
Dhenkanal, Odisha

The Changes concerning voter registration and electoral rolls cannot be

The Chief Minister
of Andhra Pradesh

Beijing's push for stability

China in particular has sought stability as it moves into 2027. Later next year, the CCP convenes the 21st Party Congress when Mr. Xi will be appointed to a record fourth term as General Secretary and where he hopes to appoint a fresh phalanx of personal loyalists to the party's most senior positions. While Mr. Xi's authority remains unchallenged, he will want as benign a domestic economic environment as possible.

China's dilemma is that the domestic drivers of economic growth are performing poorly. Private domestic consumption is in the doldrums. Private residential construction is into its sixth year of recession. Private fixed capital investment is also flat-lining. That leaves public investment (i.e., China's gargantuan techno-industrial strategy) and net exports as the two primary pistons driving the Chinese growth engine.

The last thing Beijing wants is for the U.S. to resume a full-scale trade war which Mr. Trump is perfectly capable of doing. Just look at what he did in 2018 and in 2025. China therefore has been doubling down on its "stability narrative" with the U.S. Its new concept of "constructive strategic stability" is about maximising "cooperation", managing "competition within defined bounds", while also managing "strategic differences", which is code language for Taiwan. In China's conceptual universe, if these three pillars are properly attended to, then the cardinal objective is achieved: stability.

It is an elegant schemata. It is China's effort at "managed strategic competition" with the U.S. Moreover, the U.S. has formally accepted this framework in official readouts from the Beijing

fragile truce

What concerns China most is if what is called the “Busan Tariff Truce” agreed to last October falls apart. That original 12-month truce has only been extended two months. If the U.S. concludes that China has not been helpful on U.S. agricultural exports, or in the normalisation of the critical minerals and rare earths trade with the U.S., there is a real risk that the Busan Truce collapses. And if the European Union were to move in the same direction on tariffs given the crisis in European manufacturing, the consequences for an export-dependent Chinese economy would be large.

For all these reasons, both tactical and strategic, the U.S.-China relationship remains deeply fragile. Even if the Busan Truce extends beyond December, the effective general U.S. tariff rate against China will remain much, much higher than, for example, India’s. Beyond trade, there also remains a formidable array of export controls on critical technologies, including world-class chips where China remains several years behind the U.S. And that leaves to one side a bilateral foreign investment regime which remains deeply restrictive at both ends of the relationship.

Therefore, breathless reporting about an emerging “G2” between the U.S. and China in some sort of global strategic condominium is fanciful. Whatever tactical accommodations may occur in the trade relationship, the fundamental nature of the strategic competition between Washington and Beijing continues. Remember it was Donald Trump, on the very eve of Mr. Xi’s state visit to Washington DC, who stated, “Whoever wins in AI, wins.” That is Xi Jinping’s view too. That does not exactly sound like an emerging G-2 to me.

Kevin Rudd
Global President and
CEO of Asia Society,
New York, and the
26th Prime Minister
of Australia

There is no 'G-2'
yet in U.S.-China
relations --
Washington and
Beijing may
manage their
tensions, but
their strategic
competition
remains
entrenched

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

should be able to register without hurdles. Transparency in the Election Commission is essential to restoring public trust.

Sankalp Gupta,
Dhenkanal, Odisha

The Changes concerning voter registration and electoral rolls cannot be

treated as routine administrative matters when they directly affect citizens' democratic rights. The Election Commission must ensure that every decision is transparent, accountable and supported by clear records. At the same time, allegations must be examined on the basis of

evidence rather than assumption. Public confidence in elections ultimately depends on institutions being open to scrutiny.

Albin Thekkethala,
Kallur, Thrissur, Kerala

Medicine Nobel
Many of the most significant

advances in medicine start with questions that appear to have nothing to do with the field. The 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine is a striking instance. This is something that India should take note of. Basic science requires patience, freedom, and continuous support — a

question which seems unclear in a laboratory at the present time could end up forming the basis of tomorrow's medicine.

Dr. Yash Javeri,
Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Why charging for UPI changes the math

In the decade since its launch, India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) has evolved from a promising digital experiment into critical economic infrastructure. Against this backdrop, the Union Finance Ministry has notified that the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) will operationalise a 0.4% Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on specified merchant transactions above ₹2,000 from October 15. While consumers will not be charged directly, this marks a significant departure from UPI's zero-MDR model for merchants. While the reasoning is understandable, considering the costs to run UPI, one question deserves an answer: what has UPI cost India, and what has it saved?

The costs are easy to see as servers, security and fraud controls show up on balance sheets, while the savings are scattered across the economy. For example, take a small shopkeeper. Before digital payments, taking cash meant counting notes, keeping change, guarding the till and making trips to the bank, with the added risk of theft. UPI removed most of that, with customers also saving themselves a few trips to the ATM. Further, banks now handle less physical cash, businesses reconcile accounts faster, lenders are able to read a small trader's cash flow from digital records, and most importantly, the government gets a trail that helps with formalisation and tax compliance. None of this is revenue to UPI; it is spread across banks, consumers and the exchequer.

The case for MDR is that the payments ecosystem needs a steady income to



Amerikai V. Narayanan

National Spokesperson of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), a certified public accountant (CPA) and a certified management accountant (CMA)

maintain and expand UPI, which is a fair point. Yet this logic assumes that most of UPI's cost should be recovered from the transactions on it; the wider benefits are not accounted for. Every payment that moves from cash to UPI cuts handling costs elsewhere while every merchant who joins adds to formalisation. Further, the increase in UPI users makes the network more useful to those already on it. India has acted on this logic before: the government approved ₹1,500 crore in 2024-25 alone to incentivise low-value merchant transactions, with the view that moving cash through digital networks was worth paying for.

Balancing benefits

On September 28, the Supreme Court, while declining to stay the levy, asked the Centre, the RBI and the NPCI to explain, on affidavit, the legal basis for the levy, including whether the MDR was a tax or a fee. In response, the government stated that nothing reaches the exchequer and that the money was a settlement between banks and service providers. This answers the legal question but not the economic one – what is India giving up?

Consider a highway between an industrial region and a port. A toll can be perfectly reasonable, but toll collections say little about the highway's real return, which is the faster movement of goods and the businesses that grow with it. A port is similar; while container fees pay for operations, its larger contribution is the trade that it enables. UPI also deserves the same lens. Any plan to recover its maintenance bill should ask what happens to the activity it supports once a

toll is introduced. That calculation is largely missing from the MDR debate.

MDR might raise money that lets banks and payment providers invest more in resilience and expansion. But it would also lead to a change in behaviour. Some merchants may prefer cash for transactions while others may nudge customers towards a different payment instrument. When payments slip back to cash, the costs UPI had removed come back such as handling, reconciliation, cash logistics, and less digital visibility. Some of the formalisation gains go too. If ₹100 collected in MDR causes more than ₹100 of economic value to disappear elsewhere, the payment system ends up better funded and the country poorer.

Additionally, UPI and RuPay had helped India build a domestic payments ecosystem at the expense of global card networks. The USTR had earlier called India's zero-MDR policy a market-access barrier for Visa and Mastercard; these players now stand to gain from any drift back to cards. A lasting domestic advantage should not be conceded for trade terms that can later be revised.

A network that millions of Indians rely on has to be secure, resilient and able to grow. The harder question is what "self-sustaining" should mean. The test for the new toll should be straightforward: does it increase India's overall economic return from UPI after accounting for the behaviour it may change and the wider benefits the network creates? This is the question policymakers should answer.

If ₹100 collected in MDR causes more than ₹100 of economic value to disappear elsewhere, the payment system ends up better funded and the country poorer

Indian research can shape the world

People fret about the buses India has missed in its technological growth. The list is familiar: aircraft, advanced weapons, new materials, and biotechnology. In each, we look at what others built decades ago and ask why we did not. There is value in this introspection, and there is danger. The value is that it forces us to ask whether our systems can be streamlined and enabled. Catching up is not a bad thing. Much of the world's industrial history is a history of catching up. The danger is that catch-up-itis can become a habit. If our ambition is always defined by what someone else has already done, we will always arrive late, pay for licences and know-how, and build on foundations laid elsewhere. The costs of technological catch-up are a heavy burden, and they recur with every new wave.

There is a better question to ask, and it arises from a tectonic change in the relationship between science and technology. By science, we mean discovery, curiosity, the effort to explain the universe, and the development of abstract ideas in mathematics. By technology, we mean the development of tools that enable humans to transform the world. For much of history these were treated as separate enterprises, with technology following science at a distance, sometimes by a century.

However, over the past 50 years or so we have increasingly seen fundamental research and application sewn together at the hip. Much of our understanding of how genes are regulated came from studying viruses that infect bacteria. More recently,



K. VijayRaghavan

Former Principal Scientific Adviser to the Government of India and chairs Ashoka University's Science Advisory Council



Archish Mittal

Vice-President, Iron Pillar

studying how bacteria defend themselves gave us CRISPR technology within just a few years, which has an extraordinary range of applications. Today, the distance and time from curiosity to application are short. This shift lets thinking and training lead, and it shows that investing in fundamental research will enable leading than playing catch-up. The bus we need to board is the next one, and it has not yet left.

Get on the bus first

For science from India to have global impact by developing transformative technologies, four things need to be addressed.

First, invest in high-quality education at scale. The features of AI that democratise access to learning allow us to reach millions of students poorly served by our moribund institutions, and to bypass those institutions where necessary. But learning science requires doing science. Hundreds of experimental "foundries" in engineering, physics, biology, chemistry and math should be created; places where young people work with real instruments on real problems.

Second, national laboratories need to be liberated from insularity. The bulk of our national labs are currently poorly accessible to researchers, students and companies outside their walls. This can easily change, benefiting both labs and universities. All national labs need to be organised around three zones: green for open interaction, amber for collaboration, and red for strategic work. Much of what India's labs do belong in the green and amber zones. Third is flexibility. Many

say we are a low-trust society and that our regulators should trust our research system more and be more flexible. The response to this is to point out that trust is low because compliance with guidelines is poor, necessitating onerous rules. However, India does have many high-quality islands of excellence in universities, institutes and laboratories. These institutions do comply with the rules and regulations, and should be freed from the weight of General Financial Rules compliance, a weight few other countries place on their scientists. Accountability should be measured by outcomes, and not by procedure at every step. Flexibility can allow these institutions to leap ahead.

Fourth, our regulatory system still needs much reform. Approvals for research with biological materials and for clinical trials remain slow and unpredictable. The more hoops companies and researchers must jump through, the less likely small and medium-sized institutions are to succeed, since only those with deep pockets can afford the time and costs. Thus, high-quality, speedy regulation is important.

None of this is beyond us; they can be achieved step by step. Many are already doing so in pockets. What is missing is the decision to make those pockets the norm, and a few who dedicate themselves to this task. How long will it take to become a science-driven nation with global impact? If we improve just 10% in each sector, field, and every year, we will be nearly seven times better in 20 years.

Women are twice as likely to use public transport for work commute

Nearly 67% of all women who commuted to work relied on walking or buses or other public transport

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Gandla Sneha

The National Household Travel Survey (NHTS), which captures how people in India travel to the workplace, shows a clear gender divide in mobility and the modes used to travel to work. Data shows that women are twice as likely as men to commute to work using public transport such as buses or trains or on foot compared to men. Nearly 67% of all women who commuted to work relied on walking or buses or other public transport. This figure was only 33% for all men who commuted to work (Chart 1). In rural areas, more than half of all women who were working walked to their workplaces. However, a large share of men were dependent on two-wheelers.

While two-wheelers remained a major mode of transport for both men and women in urban areas, women were not solely reliant on two-wheelers.

A Statewise analysis shows that the share of women walking to work rather than relying on buses was higher than the national average in the central and northeastern States, including M.P., U.P. and Bihar (Chart 2) signifying low public transport availability. In southern States such as Kerala, the gap between women taking buses in rural and urban areas reduced significantly.

While women in urban areas also rely on other means such as autos and cars, they still take slightly longer than men to commute to work. In at least 13 major States, a higher share of men commuted to work in around 30 minutes compared to women (Chart 3).

The use of public transport reflects the cost of commuting too. Though women's expenditure on commute is lower than that of men in rural areas, the gap is reducing in urban areas (Chart 4).

The commute divide

Data for the charts were sourced from the National Household Travel Survey conducted by the National Statistics Office (NSO). The survey was conducted between July 2025 and June 2026 covering 2,84,769 rural and 2,07,254 urban households. The analysis pertains only to the share of workers aged 15 and above and a trip is defined as travel covering a distance of more than 1 km



Chart 1: The share of men, women and persons using different modes of transport to commute to work. Figures in %

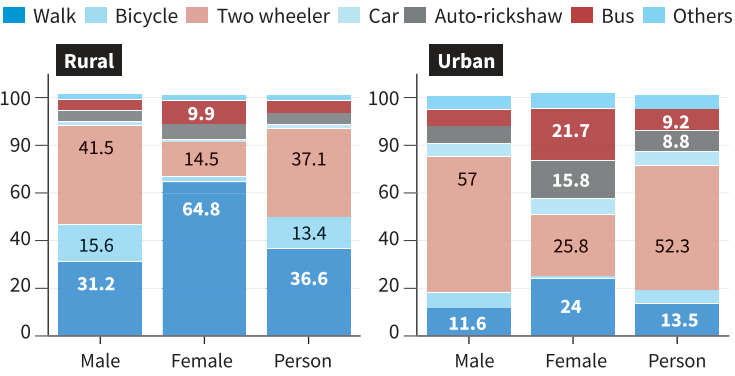


Chart 2: Share of women who either walked or used the bus as a primary mode of transport to commute to work. Data pertains to major States only. Figures in %

■ In States like M.P., U.P., Bihar and Chhattisgarh, rural women are overwhelmingly dependent on walking. For instance, in Madhya Pradesh, 88.7% of rural women walked and only 2.0% used the bus. This could signal either lack of access to public transport or proximity of workplaces

■ In Kerala, only 20.1% of rural women walked, while 48.6% used the bus. This is the highest share of rural women using the bus for their commute in the country. In general, the share of women walking to work reduces in urban areas

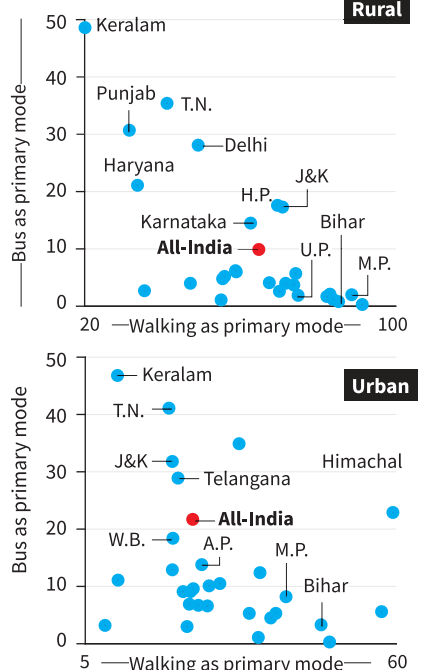


Chart 3: State-wise share of men and women who commute to work within 30 minutes. Figures in %

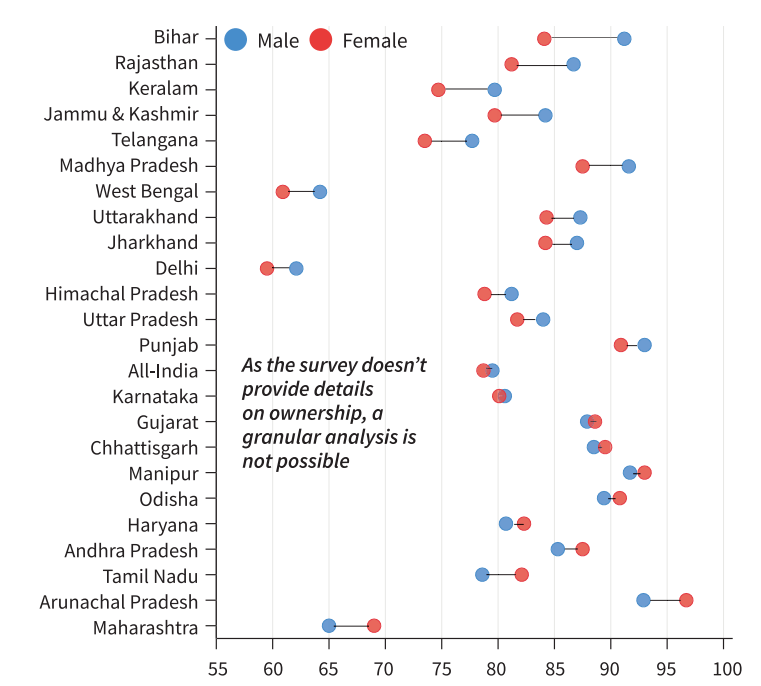
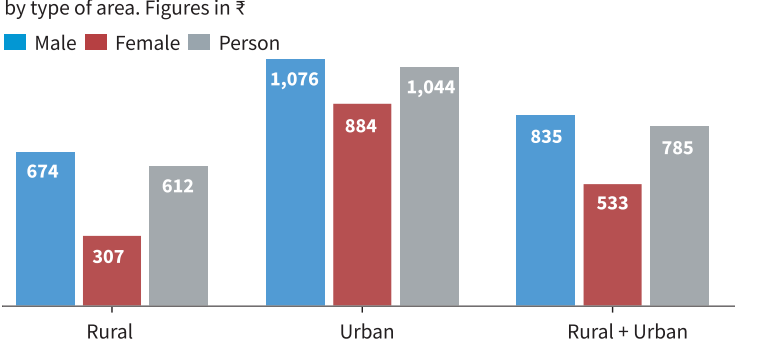


Chart 4: Average monthly cost of commuting to work for men, women and persons by type of area. Figures in ₹



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu**.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 7, 1976

'Aluminium conductors cause phone faults'

Hyderabad, October 6: Due to the extensive use of aluminium conductors, quite often "disconnection faults occur on the telephone lines", resulting in the telephones becoming 'dead', according to Mr. K.S. Krishnamurthy Rao, Sub-Divisional Officer, Telephones, at the Saifabad Exchange here.

In a paper presented at the seminar on "Improved Service to Telephone Users", organised by the Junior Engineers (Telcom) Association, Mr. Krishnamurthy Rao said an expert committee constituted by the Indian Post and Telegraphs Department had "discouraged" the use of aluminium conductors and suggested "reversion to copper". "If this is implemented, I am sure, we will be improving our services to a large extent", he said.

Presiding over the seminar, held at the Regional Telcom Training Centre on Abid Road, Prof Alladi Prabhakar, Head of Osmania University's Department of Electronics and Communication Engineering, called for an integrated telecommunication network which could deal not only with voice communication but also facsimile, video and other media. He emphasised the vital role of electronic switching in this regard.

In his paper, Mr. Krishnamurthy Rao observed that the maintenance aspect had not been forgotten by the department in the course of the vast expansion of telecommunication services.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 7, 1926

Fighting malaria in Indian plantations

London, October 6: Under the auspices of the Indian Tea Association, Sir Ronald Ross will leave for India on 29th October on board 'Rajpatanam'. He will travel to Calcutta via Malay States with the object of inspecting measures for the control of malaria, that are being carried out in the plantations in India and Malay States. While in Malay States, he will be the guest of Sir Watson. Sir Ronald Ross will unveil at Calcutta a commemorative tablet in his old laboratory at the Presidency General Hospital. He will also lecture at the Calcutta School of Tropical Medicine.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

India's data centre sector investment commitments

173 in \$ billion. India's data centre (DC) market added about 130 MW of new capacity in the first six months of 2026, while more than 200 MW is expected to go live in the second half of the year, CBRE said in a report released on Tuesday. Hyperscale and co-location investments accounted for close to 62% of the cumulative DC commitments. PTI

Amount Zambia will sign in U.S. five-year health deal

3.6 in \$ billion. Zambia will sign a revised health agreement with the U.S. that will not include contentious clauses committing the African nation to share data with the U.S. government. The U.S. has signed new bilateral health agreements with around two dozen African nations since last year, but some have pushed back on requirements to provide patient data. PTI

Indian crew members injured in ship hit by projectile in Hormuz

11 Eleven Indian crew members were injured on Tuesday after a Panama-flagged commercial vessel was hit by a projectile while transiting the Strait of Hormuz. The vessel, *MT On Peace*, carried 19 crew members, including 17 Indian nationals. The Ministry of External Affairs said continuing incidents of attacks on shipping in the region remain a "cause of deep concern" for India. PTI

Ukrainian drones downed overnight, according to Russia

900 Russian air defences intercepted nearly 900 Ukrainian drones overnight over multiple regions of the country, as well as the occupied Crimean Peninsula and the Sea of Azov, the Defence Ministry in Moscow said on Tuesday. Unconfirmed reports said a major fuel depot in the Moscow region was on fire after the attack that killed two people. PTI

Students who received bicycles under Delhi's Vidya Vahini Yojana

18,000 Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Tuesday distributed bicycles to 581 Class 9 girl students under the government's Vidya Vahini Yojana, aimed at making the daily commute to school easier and promoting independence among girls. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The status of U.S. blockade on Cuba

U.S. blockade and decades-old embargo on Cuba have worsened the island's economic and humanitarian crisis, with fuel shortages disrupting electricity, food distribution, healthcare; as Havana seeks to ease the crisis, Trump administration's pressure and demand for regime change continue to constrain Cuba's options

WORLD INSIGHT

Srinivasan Ramani
Sambavi Parthasarathy

The story so far:

It has been nearly nine months since the U.S. President Donald Trump signed an executive order threatening tariffs on any country that supplies Cuba with oil, and the U.S. Coast Guard began intercepting tankers and ships bound for the island. Power cuts in Cuba have since become very common, often lasting beyond 12 hours a day and even close to 20 hours in some provinces. Independent UN human rights experts condemned these actions, calling them “energy starvation” and an “unlawful blockade” of the island country, as the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights reported. In July 2026, the UN General Assembly voted 136-9 (with 30 abstentions) to debate the blockade despite U.S. objections. Mr. Trump, meanwhile, has threatened a takeover of the island nation – a threat that is unlawful according to the UN Charter, which prohibits “the threat or use of force” against a country’s political independence. The new blockade is over and above a 64-year-old embargo by the U.S.

Embargo or blockade?

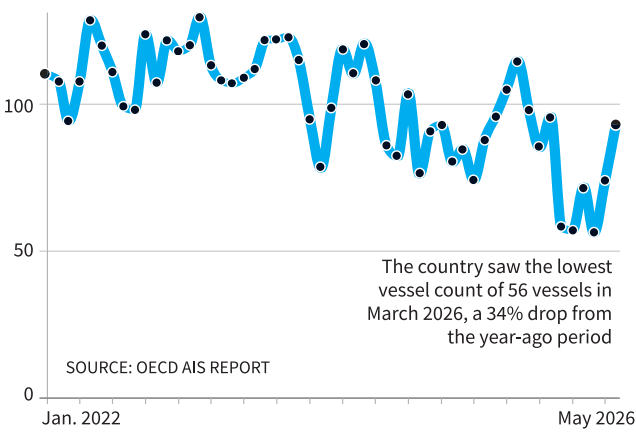
Following the 1959 Cuban revolution, the Cuban government led by Fidel Castro nationalised U.S.-owned property in 1959-60. The U.S. responded, imposing a partial “embargo” on Cuban trade in October 1960 and making it full-fledged in 1962. Cuba terms the measures *el bloqueo*, or a blockade, as it goes beyond mere bilateral trade and is exemplified by further measures taken by the U.S. on Cuban foreign trade. The Cuban Democracy Act of 1992 barred foreign subsidiaries of U.S. firms from trading in Cuba, and the Helms-Burton Act of 1996 wrote the embargo into law, so that only the U.S. Congress can lift it. It also allowed lawsuits against foreign firms using property in Cuba that was confiscated from the Americans.

After coming to power, Mr. Trump expanded further on these punitive measures by bringing Cuba back on the State Sponsors of Terrorism list (without any justification after it was briefly removed by the outgoing Biden administration in January 2025). This has meant that banks find it difficult to deal with Cuban entities. In May, the Trump administration imposed secondary sanctions on foreign firms dealing with the Cuban state and its military conglomerate, GAESA. It has also indicted former Cuban President Raul Castro on problematic charges, besides the January 29 order, which declared a national emergency and authorised extra duties on goods from any country that sells or provides oil to Cuba.

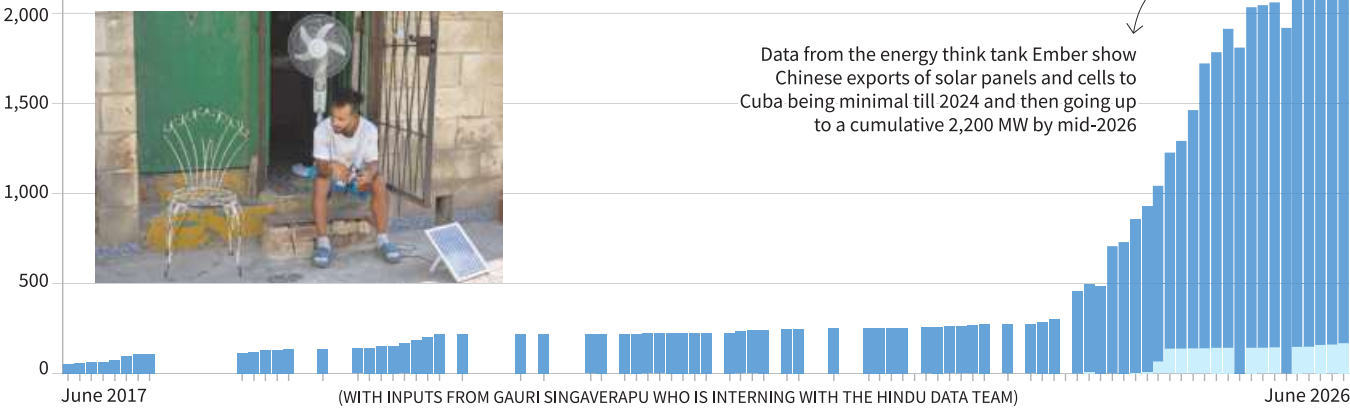
Year after year in the UN General Assembly, since 1992, there has been near-unanimous demand to end the “embargo”, but the resolutions are not binding, and this has allowed the U.S. to continue it. Havana claims that the cumulative damage of the embargo has been to the tune of \$178.7 billion and \$8.08 billion in the year up to February 2026 itself, which includes just one month of the fuel blockade. These costs are not just lost U.S. trade, but also the impact on Cuba’s overall trade because of what the embargo imposes. For example, ships docking in Cuba are barred from

Fragile lifelines | Fewer ships and disrupted trade underline growing pressure on Cuba's economy

The chart shows the number of vessels en route to Cuba



The chart shows the export of solar panels and cells to Cuba (in capacity)



U.S. ports for 180 days, which has led to increased freight costs. With the U.S. imposing financial sanctions, banks refuse Cuban payments, and imports of medical equipment and machinery have also been affected.

Has this hostility against Cuba always been the case?

U.S. policy towards Cuba has been motivated largely by the lobbying efforts of Cuban exiles based in Miami, Florida, who fled the island following the Revolution. These hardliners include those born to Cuban-immigrant parents, such as current Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who have sought the collapse of the communist system in Cuba. They have also strongly backed the Trump administration’s actions, as making conditions that are “ripe for regime change”, according to the International Crisis Group.

The hostility against Cuba experienced a brief thaw during former President Barack Obama’s second tenure. In December 2014, he and Raul Castro announced a normalisation of ties, which led to embassies reopening, Cuba being taken off the terrorism list, and culminating in a visit to Havana by Mr Obama. Travel and remittance rules were eased, but the embargo still stayed. Mr. Trump reverted much of it during his first tenure before imposing stronger restrictions in his second tenure, which intensified after U.S. forces attacked Venezuela and abducted its president, Nicolas Maduro and took control over the Latin American country’s fuel and energy resources since then.

Why was Venezuela an important lifeline for Cuba?

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, which affected the Cuban economy severely, leading to what was called a “special period”, Fidel Castro and Hugo Chavez signed an “oil-for-services” agreement in 2000. This led to the Barrio Adentro health missions (neighbourhood medical services) provided by Cuban

doctors in Venezuela. Some 40,000 Cuban doctors, teachers and other professionals worked in Venezuela, while the country supplied about 1,00,000 barrels of oil a day on relatively easy terms. Cuba also resold some of the oil for hard currency, according to U.S. officials, to mitigate the impact of the U.S. financial sanctions.

Meanwhile, mismanagement of the state oil company PDVSA, the 2014 crash in oil prices and later U.S. sanctions cut Venezuela’s oil output to a third by the late 2010s, leading to lowered shipments to Cuba. The imports met, by late 2025, only about a quarter of Cuban demand for oil and about a third of its oil imports.

In January 2026, that came to naught too after the U.S. took control of Venezuela’s oil sector. Mexico, which had supplied about 44% of Cuba’s oil imports, then suspended deliveries. Russia has not been able to step up and fill in the gap either, with just sporadic ships managing to deliver supplies to Cuba since the naval blockade.

What was the impact of the fuel blockade?

The International Crisis Group lists “severe disruption to transportation, food distribution, health care, water systems and communications” in the country. On May 7, three UN Special Rapporteurs said fuel scarcity was keeping people from hospitals and children from school. They cited a backlog of more than 96,000 surgeries, 11,000 of them for children, and delays in infant immunisation.

The scale of the impact is shown in satellite imagery data. An index of night-time light intensity built from NASA satellite data, a proxy for electricity use, fell from about 10-12 in 2021-25 to around six by mid-2026. Ships reaching Cuba have been reduced from 100-120 a month to just 50-60 in early 2026 and oil cargoes have become sporadic. The impact of the sanctions has also meant a large drop in employment in industries such as tourism – which the Cuban government sought to utilise to shore up its dollar reserves –

and mining and shipping. The naval blockade has also occurred at a time when one in five Cubans have emigrated in the past five years due to the weak economy.

How is China helping Cuba mitigate the fuel shortage?

On September 23, President Miguel Diaz-Canel said that Cuba has installed 1,418 MW of solar capacity in 144 parks and would pass 1,500 MW by the end of 2026. He said that renewables already generate 21.4% of the country’s electricity. Much of the equipment for these installations have arrived from China. Data from the energy think tank Ember show Chinese exports of solar panels and cells to Cuba being minimal till 2024 and then going up to a cumulative 2,200 MW by mid-2026. In September, reports showed that a third batch of 5,000 standalone solar systems donated by China arrived for public buildings and isolated homes, after shipments in August and November 2025. But power blackouts persist because solar power is not generated after sunset, when demand peaks and battery storage is inadequate in Cuba. The power grid also relies on aging oil-fired plants.

Chinese customs data also show China’s imports from Cuba rising from about \$50 million in 2015 to \$320 million in 2022, with commodities such as zinc ores, nickel products, lead and silver ores, lobsters, cigars and rum. But this trade fell to \$230 million in 2025 and \$145 million roughly in 2026 so far.

What other reforms has Havana embarked upon?

Havana approved 176 reforms in June to expand private enterprise and foreign investment, but the blockade continues to stymie these. Back-channel talks with the Trump administration have continued but there is little progress because the latter demands regime change while Havana insists that it “will not compromise on its sovereignty or political constitution”, according to ICG.

THE GIST

The U.S. has tightened pressure on Cuba through secondary sanctions, restrictions on foreign firms and a fuel blockade, building on the 64-year-old embargo that has raised trade, shipping and financial costs for Havana

Venezuela’s oil-for-services arrangement had long been a crucial lifeline for Cuba, but falling Venezuelan production, U.S. intervention and the suspension of Mexican supplies have left the island struggling to meet its fuel needs

Cuba is turning to Chinese-backed solar power and reforms to private enterprise and foreign investment to cope, but inadequate battery storage, an ageing power grid and continued sanctions have limited their impact

Why growing trust in digital payments may be leaving Indians more exposed to cybercrime

UPI has become a more trusted and frequently used mode of payment in India; but SPIR 2026 finds a paradox, people who trusted online banking the most and used UPI most often were more likely to have been victims of cybercrime; report shows how fraud networks exploit this trust through deceptive schemes, fake apps and ‘digital arrest’

Vinson Prakash

At a roadside tea stall, the QR code neatly taped on the can of biscuits now does more work than the cash box. A scan, a password, and a reassuring beep. No change to count, no note to fumble. In a country where your vegetable vendor, the auto driver and the doctor all get paid the same way, digital payments, especially UPI, have become a site where one’s bread and butter are bought and sold.

The scale is hard to overstate. UPI has processed over 24,000 crore transactions in FY 2025-26, with the transaction values crossing ₹314 lakh crore. As the world’s most populous country, India has 70% of its population connected to the internet, making it one of the most sought-after global markets for internet services and digital platforms. That vast, eager, and active user base is also a tempting target. One that is ripe to be picked on by cybercriminals. The Status of Policing in India Report (SPIR) 2026 shows how the two meet: how India uses the internet and how cybercriminals stay one step ahead of users.

Digital payments are a daily habit for Indians. About half (49%) of the respondents use UPI apps every day, while another quarter (24%) use them once or twice a week. UPI also stood out as the most frequently used online payment method, with almost half (48%) saying they use it “many times”, ahead of card, wallet, and NEFT/RTGS payment methods (Table 1).

Trust follows usage. UPI garnered the most trust out of all payment

The trust test

UPI dominates online payments, but the SPIR 2026 data shows that high trust and frequent use can coexist with greater exposure to cybercrime

Table 1: UPI is the most frequently used for of online payment

Online payment modes	Frequency of use		
	Many times	Sometimes	Never
UPI	48	30	19
Debit/credit card payment	20	40	33
Payment wallets	14	25	49
NEFT/RTGS	7	23	57

Note: All figures are in percentages. The rest did not respond. The categories ‘never’ and ‘I don’t make online payments’ are merged to form the ‘never’ category.

Question asked: When making payments online, how frequently do you use the following a) UPI b) NEFT/RTGS c) Debit/credit card payment d) Payment wallets – many times, sometimes, or never?



Table 2: Those who consider online banking to be safe are more likely to be victims of cybercrime

Index of perceived safety of various modes of online banking	Have you been a victim of a cybercrime or helped the victim closely in cyber complaint registration/handling the issue?	
	Yes	No
Very safe	28	65
Somewhat safe	26	70
Somewhat unsafe	22	73
Very unsafe	14	80

Note: All figures are in percentages. The rest did not respond.

Question asked: Have you been a victim of a cybercrime in the last 2-3 years; or did you help the victim closely in registering the cyber complaint or in handling the overall issue?

Question asked: In your opinion, how safe are these modes of online banking: a) UPI b) Mobile banking apps c) Internet banking websites d) Debit/credit card payments g) Wallet-based apps – very safe, somewhat safe, somewhat unsafe, or very unsafe?

methods, with a third (34%) of the respondents considering it “very safe” and two in five (41%) considering it “somewhat safe”, meaning three in four people consider it to be safe. Card payments came in second, with about two in three (65%) considering it safe – 28% considering it ‘very safe’ and 37% ‘somewhat safe’ – followed by wallet-based apps and mobile banking

apps. Taking all online banking modes together, a majority of the respondents find them to be safe, with about a quarter (23%) finding them “very safe” and about two in five (40%) finding them “somewhat safe”.

On its own, this is a success story. People trust a system they use constantly, and the system mostly delivers.

The trust paradox

SPIR also asked a different set of questions about behaviour, which together measure how vulnerable a person is to unsafe online practices. Would they open a link from an unverified sender? A photo, video, or file from a stranger? Share an OTP with an unknown caller? And so on.

When trust is set beside vulnerability, the pattern is striking. The people most prone to unsafe online practices were also the most confident about online banking. Among the highly vulnerable, about half (49%) called online banking modes “very safe” and another 39% considered them “somewhat safe”. Among those with moderate to no vulnerability, only about a fifth, on average, considered online banking to be “very safe”.

Following this thread towards victimisation, it was found that those who considered online banking modes as “very safe” were also more likely to have been victims of cybercrimes in the past 2-3 years. Among victims, 28% considered online banking modes to be “very safe” compared with 14% who considered online banking modes ‘very unsafe’ (Table 2). As perceptions of safety decreased, so did their likelihood of being a victim.

Usage tells the same story. Those who use UPI “many times” were more likely to have been victims of cybercrime in the last 2-3 years, compared to those who “never” use it.

People’s high trust and usage of online banking methods is being met with an adversary that is organised and inventive. A cybercrime expert in the report described a supply chain

that sells fraudsters “kits” of pre-activated SIM cards, bank accounts, and cell phones. For a small investment of ₹10,000-20,000 in these kits, the fraudsters can swindle someone’s life savings worth tens of lakhs or crores, and remain largely untraceable. The interviewed victims further shed light on the various inventive schemes cybercriminals use to defraud people. The fraudsters create entire investment/betting apps, convincingly hold victims under digital arrest for several days, and gain victims’ trust and convince them to share personal information.

The deception does not stop at victims. Two people interviewed for the report, both accused of perpetrating cybercrime, said they had lent their bank accounts to fraudsters who deceived them, leaving them part of a crime they did not fully understand. Fraudsters are not only exploiting gaps in the financial system, but they are recruiting its users and leaving them to be apprehended by the police as the most replaceable link in the chain, while they themselves go untouched.

The SPIR 2026 points to an almost paradoxical association: the more people use digital payments, the more they trust them, and the more likely they are to be victims of cybercrime. But that is only one half of the picture. The other half is a sophisticated adversary who is armed with the right tools, exploits the trust people have in their financial systems, and quite tactfully plays on the human psyche to deceive their victims.

(Vinson Prakash is a researcher at Common Cause)

Cyber fraud victims dissatisfied with banks over delayed action and poor recovery support: study

13% of respondents experienced cybercrime in the past two to three years, with 54% of victims reporting digital financial fraud; while most victims approached banks within 24 hours, many reported delays in blocking unauthorised transactions, poor support and banks’ reluctance to accept liability; victims, experts also raised several concerns

Radhika Jha

Cybercrimes have disrupted our conventional understanding of both how crimes take place and how the systems responding to them function. While there is much to be said about the non-financial cybercrimes that may be just as prevalent as financial cybercrimes, the latter have captured the public’s imagination and fears in unprecedented ways.

A recent study by Common Cause and Lokniti, CSDS, the Status of Policing in India Report (SPIR) 2026: Cybercrimes – Victim Perspectives and Systemic Responses, brings out the perspectives of the common public, victims, and domain experts on this issue, focusing on how victims navigate through the complex systems. The study is based on a survey of 8,306 respondents from across 16 States/U.T.s, along with in-depth interviews with 37 stakeholders, including victims, cybercrime experts, and others.

In financial cybercrime cases, the banking sector becomes an integral part of the reporting and resolution process, widening the traditional understanding of the core criminal justice institutions such as the police and courts. In this context, the study explores, among other things, whether banks as an institution are prepared to deal with these cases and to take accountability for security lapses.

According to the survey data, 13% of the overall respondents were victims of cybercrimes in the last 2-3 years. Among the victims, more than half (54%) were victims of digital financial frauds.

One of the first actions taken by the victim after the incident was complaining directly to the banks. More than half of the victims of digital financial fraud (52%) who were surveyed said that they had complained to the bank separately after the incident. A majority, 63%, complained within the first 24 hours.

Banks’ response

Despite the promptness in reporting shown by many victims, the response by the banks leaves much to be

Banking on banks

Table 1: More than half of all cybercrimes involve digital financial frauds

Nature of crime	Victims
Digital financial frauds	54
Hacking of devices	13
Personal data theft	11
Cyberbullying/abuse on social media	7
Online sexual harassment	4

Note: The rest did not respond or reported facing other types of crime. All figures are in percentages

Question: What type of crime did you face?

Table 2: Nearly two out of three respondents reported the fraud to the bank within 24 hours

Time taken to report the fraud after it occurred	Victims/respondents who assisted victims of cybercrimes (%)
Within 24 hours	63
Within 48 hours	21
More than 48 hours	11

Note: The rest did not respond.

Question asked: How soon after the fraud did you/they report it- within 24 hours, within 48 hours, more than 48 hours?

desired. A 2017 RBI guideline states that in cases of third-party breach due to no deficiency by either the bank or the customer, and if the customer notifies the bank within three days, the loss must be borne by the bank entirely. This was extended on a pilot basis in 2026 to include those cases wherein the customer had been tricked or coerced into making scam payments, with limited liability being placed on the bank in such cases.

In-depth interviews with victims revealed, however, that the banks’ response to cybercrimes is almost entirely focused on evading accountability and liability. The standard response from the banks in cases of digital financial fraud is that the victim “collaborated” with the perpetrator of the cybercrime. All the victims of digital financial cybercrimes who were interviewed qualitatively, barring one, said that the bank maintained this in their case, even in cases where the victims did not interact with the perpetrators at any point. Notably, the one case in which the banks did not give this response included a high net-worth individual

Victims often report fraud quickly, but face delays and poor support when seeking recovery

Table 3: Two-fifths of the victims who complained separately to the bank feel that crime occurred due to a breach of personal data

Complained made separately to the bank (among victim)	Yes, it occurred due to a breach of personal data	No, it didn’t happen because of the breach of personal data
Yes	40	44
No	26	54

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures are in percentages.

Question asked: Some victims of financial cybercrimes believe that their financial data was leaked by a bank insider because of which they were targeted by criminals. In your case, do you think the crime occurred due to a breach of your personal data by the bank or its personnel?

Statement 1: Yes, it occurred due to a breach of personal data; Statement 2: No, it didn’t happen because of that.

Table 4: Nearly a quarter of the victims of cyber fraud are very dissatisfied with the bank’s role in recovery of money

	Degree of satisfaction			
	Very satisfied	Somewhat satisfied	Somewhat dissatisfied	Very dissatisfied
The bank’s role in recovering the money	11	21	16	22

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures are in percentages. The table includes responses from both the victims and those who assisted cybercrime victims of digital financial fraud.

Question asked: How satisfied were you with the following – very satisfied, somewhat satisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, or very dissatisfied?

with a long-standing relationship with the bank.

Low satisfaction

Vipin (name changed), a Gurgaon-based journalist, got a scam call for SIM upgradation on a Saturday. The caller, pretending to be an Airtel employee, shared some of his personal information to appear legitimate, including his name, date of birth, Aadhaar number, and debit card number. Despite cutting the call, ₹5,000 was withdrawn from a payment wallet linked to his number the following day. He immediately blocked his number and emailed his bank, since it was closed on Sunday. However, by Monday afternoon, his account had still not been blocked, and the fraudsters had taken a loan of ₹5 lakhs against his credit card, half of which had already been withdrawn. The bank, however, took “zero accountability” for this loss and was “apathetic” to the complaint, as reported by him.

Other victims reported similar instances of delays by the banks in stopping the flow of unauthorised

transactions immediately following the complaint. While the banks become directly liable for such losses when presented with such evidence of negligence in taking prompt action, there is little accountability for the mental, physical and financial costs to the victim in the recovery process necessitated by such negligence

Data (in)security

A more serious allegation levelled against the banks, both by cybercrime experts as well as victims, is that of complicity in the cybercrimes, whether directly or indirectly. The survey data shows that amongst victims who complained to the bank separately, as many as 40% were of the opinion that the cybercrime occurred due to their financial data being leaked by a bank insider. Amongst those who did not complain to the bank separately, 26% hold this opinion. Overall, while a significant proportion of the victims feel that the breach of their personal data enabled the cybercrime incident, this sentiment is amplified amongst those who had first-hand experience with the bank in

dealing with their case.

In-depth interviews with victims made similar grave allegations against the banks. Of the 13 digital financial fraud victims interviewed, five victims were of the opinion that bank officials were directly or indirectly complicit in the crime. One of the victims was told by the police officer investigating her case that the bank must be complicit, though no charges were filed against it.

Cybercrime experts and senior police officers dealing with these cases strongly supported this perception. They further stressed the lack of accountability for the common leakages of customer data, due to inadequate security systems.

Another major systemic loophole is the lack of due diligence by banks when opening bank accounts, which can be used as mule accounts in cybercrime cases. Policing and cybercrime experts were of the opinion that banks prioritise their business interests over building secure systems. “People like you and me will lose access to our accounts due to KYC procedures, but these accounts [the cyber criminals’] will never be closed”, stated a former police officer.

Satisfaction with the banks

Overall, the levels of satisfaction with the banks remained low across the victims of digital financial cybercrimes, as is emerging both from the survey data as well as the in-depth interviews with victims. More than one out of five victims of digital financial fraud surveyed reported being “very dissatisfied” with the bank’s role in recovering money, while 16% said that they were somewhat dissatisfied.

Amongst the in-depth interview respondents, the satisfaction levels were lower, with the victims rating the banks a poor one out of five. Even in cases where the victims were able to recover their money fully or partially, the satisfaction with the banks remained low. Notably, there was not much variation in the reported experience or satisfaction levels across private and public-sector banks. (Radhika Jha is Project Lead (Rule of Law) at Common Cause and lead researcher and author of the Status of Policing in India Report (SPIR) series. Views expressed are personal)

Slowdown in money-fund cash flow hits short-term Treasuries



Worrying aspect: Reduced money-fund inflows have hit demand for T-bills, analysts say. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

A stream of investor cash flowing into money-market funds has slowed significantly this year, pushing up yields on Treasury bills and potentially leaving markets vulnerable to short-term funding issues.

Money fund inflows have totalled just \$158 billion in the first three quarters this year, TD Securities data show, down from \$823 billion for the full year of 2025 and \$840 billion in 2024.

Reduced money-fund inflows have hit demand for T-bills, analysts said, lifting their yields in recent sessions relative to comparable overnight index swaps (OIS), a key money market benchmark that reflects Federal Reserve rate-increase expectations embedded in swap markets. “If money funds are not getting those inflows, then they have to think about where they want to put their money,” said Sam Earl, U.S. rates strategist at Barclays.

Net buyers of Treasuries

Money market funds, however, remain net buyers of Treasury bills, though demand has slowed markedly. By the end of August, those holdings had increased roughly 4% from year-end 2025, according to the latest Investment Company Institute data, versus an 18% rise over all of 2025.

That softer pace of demand is beginning to show up in the relative pricing of Treasury bills, with investors requiring a larger premium to hold them. U.S. 3-month bill yields rose nearly 10 basis points above 3-month OIS on Monday, after hitting last week the widest spread since September 2024.

For six-month maturities , that spread was at 11.3 basis points on Monday, touching 12.5 last week, the highest since April 2025.

The spread measures the bill’s valuation relative to the market’s implied path for short-term Fed policy. If T-bills are yielding more, it suggests investors are demanding extra compensation to hold U.S. short-term debt, typically valued for liquidity and near risk-free status.

Nafis Smith, principal and head of taxable money markets at Vanguard, said the strength of the U.S. equity market this year has helped crimp money fund flows by reducing the investor impulse to put money into cash. The S&P 500 is up 13% this year and the Nasdaq is up 18%.

Alongside the slowdown in money-fund buying, the rise in bill yields reflects expectations of heavy Treasury supply in the fourth quarter and more interest rate hikes from the Federal Reserve, analysts said.

Barclays estimates that the Treasury will issue roughly \$225 billion of bills in October and another \$160 billion in November.

National PNG Drive 3.0 expands piped gas outreach, powers cleaner future

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) new drive aims to add 50 lakh new piped gas connections, convert 40 lakh unbilled connections into active users and register 50 lakh more users by the end of the fiscal year 2027; The broader objective is to accelerate its adoption

EXPLAINER

Saptaparno Ghosh

The story so far: The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), along with city-gas distributors and oil-marketing companies, October 1 launched the National PNG Drive 3.0 with the target of enrolling 50 lakh domestic-piped natural gas (D-PNG) connections by the end of the fiscal year 2027.

The broader objective was to accelerate the adoption of piped natural gas, facilitate transition from liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to PNG and further ensure the existing infrastructure for PNG is effectively utilised to attain these objectives.

Push for PNG

The government’s objective for promoting piped natural gas across consumer segments primarily rested on spurring access to cleaner fuels and increasing the role of natural gas in the national energy basket. This directly aligns with India’s broader net-zero commitments and sustainable development goals, as well as ensuring access to cleaner, reliable and sustainable energy, it had stated.

The PNG Drives therefore were conceived as a structured intervention



New wave: Piped Natural Gas (PNG) installed in a house. THE HINDU

that sought to bridge the gap between network creation and consumer adoption, two imperative pillars that were to expand the adoption of piped gas ecosystem.

Transitioning to piped natural gas received a further impetus during the West Asia crisis with varied government orders that sought to expedite potential transition. This was primarily aimed at easing off pressure on LPG, supplies of which were bothered because of the conflict spanning across the energy route, Strait of Hormuz.

What is Drive 3.0?

The National PNG Drive 3.0 is not only targeting to add 50 lakh new domestic-PNG connections but also to convert 40 lakh connec-



As on June 30, India had 1.74 crore PNG users. Among other things, the 3.0 drive seeks to hasten the adoption in newly connected, semi-urban and rural areas

tions into active users and register another 50 lakh users.

As on June 30, India had 1.74 crore PNG consumers of which 1.15 crore were billed consumers. Among other things, the 3.0 drive seeks to hasten adoption in newly connected, semi-urban and rural areas.

It also rests focus on converting connected-but-unbilled consumers into

active consumers.

Albeit, in a broader context, the closure report for PNG Drive 2.0 (published July 7) had also apprehended about the time taken for converting consumer interest into active usage.

“The pre-campaign baseline itself indicated a significant gap between connected domestic PNG users and billed users,” it had observed. Thus, the 3.0 drive underlines this among the imperatives.

Additionally, the drive would also endow focus on maximising utilisation and gasification of existing infrastructure of city-gas distributors.

According to the regulator’s estimates, the country at present has about 6.9 lakh inch-kms of laid pipeline (inclusive of approxi-

Uzbekistan investors watch reform staying power

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
TASHKENT/LONDON

When Nika Kurdiani began to plot London-listed Georgian lender TBC Bank’s expansion into Uzbekistan around 2018, he had to bring plastic bags full of banknotes to pay restaurant bills.

The country of nearly 40 million people – Central Asia’s most populous – had long been largely closed to foreign investment by strict capital controls. Its currency, the sum, was artificially overvalued and credit cards rarely accepted, forcing consumers to carry wads of cash for everyday purchases.

But after almost a de-



Business-friendly: A fruit vendor checks her phone at Chorsu Bazaar in Tashkent, Uzbekistan REUTERS

cade of economic reform that has helped growth outpace that of most ex-Soviet peers, digital payments are ubiquitous. TBC Uzbekistan, one of few foreign lenders operating in a still mostly state-owned banking sector, is considering an initial public offering (IPO) separate from its

Georgian parent.

No carrying cash

“Now there is no need whatsoever to carry cash anywhere in the country,” Kurdiani, CEO of TBC’s Uzbekistan business, told Reuters in an interview at the bank’s Tashkent headquarters.

The changes have begun to attract international investors. In May, Uzbekistan’s National Investment Fund, a portfolio of minority stakes in state-owned companies managed by Franklin Templeton, raised \$690 million in the London Stock Exchange’s biggest IPO since 2021, drawing over \$2.8 billion orders.

Meaningful reforms

“The reforms have been meaningful in our view, and they are much more open towards market practices,” said Leonard Kwan, a fixed-income portfolio manager at T. Rowe Price, which is overweight on Uzbekistan.

But as the government says it will push ahead with further privatisations, investors say the next test is whether business-friendly

changes can become embedded in a country where market-oriented policies remain relatively new and their staying power unclear.

Reform sustainability

“The biggest risk the country has is the sustainability of all those reforms and the consistency of their implementation,” said Kurdiani.

Policies launched since President Shavkat Mirziyoyev took office in 2016 have opened up a country that had largely shunned the outside world following independence in 1991.

Capital controls have been lifted, the currency has been floated and visa rules eased for most Western visitors.

“The country was effectively closed. It was closed to investors, to visitors,”

Laziz Kudratov, Uzbekistan’s investment minister, told Reuters.

The reforms “led foreign investors, who are seeking new markets and new growth opportunities, to turn their attention to Uzbekistan and begin actively expanding their operations here,” Kudratov said. The Uzbek economy has grown by an average of around 6% over the last five years, faster than most of its neighbours.

Foreign direct investment rose to \$4.4 billion in 2025 from \$2.3 billion in 2021, according to World Bank and United Nations data, although it remains relatively modest as a share of gross domestic product. State-owned enterprises still dominate key sectors like banking, energy and mining.

AI hopes, industrial malaise drive boom in German startups

Reuters
BERLIN

German industry – long the foundation of Europe’s biggest economy – may be in free fall, but its once anaemic startup sector is experiencing an unprecedented AI-led boom that has the potential to offset the malaise and even benefit from it.

More than 3,000 startups were founded in Germany in the first half of 2026, according to economy ministry data. That’s an all-time record and a 52% increase from the previous six months.

Experts point to the growing availability of capital and the global explosion in artificial intelligence (AI) as fuelling the trend. Around a third of

the new German companies are AI-focused.

But weakness in the wider labour market has also diverted talented individuals away from previously safe corporate jobs. New government measures to facilitate startups, meanwhile, aim to develop that entrepreneurial spirit at a time when Germany is in dire need of an economic boost. “The momentum is coming at the right time,” said Verena Pausder, head of the German Startup Association. “Large parts of industry are fighting for their existence.”

Industry fights for life Germany lost around 4,00,000 industrial jobs between 2019 and 2025 due to competition from China, according to an esti-



New paradigm: People attend a startup event at a pop-up store in Berlin, Germany. REUTERS

mate from the German Economic Institute IW. Automakers like Volkswagen and Mercedes and heavy industry giants including Thyssenkrupp have been hit particularly

hard. German industry’s existential crisis, however, is creating an opportunity for hundreds of small German startups offering AI-based solutions to help companies cut costs and

automate routine work.

“We have a lot of legacy industry that does now have to reinvent itself,” said Hendrik Hofstadt, chief technology officer at Berlin-based Langdock,

whose software is designed to help companies adopt and benefit from AI.

Founded three years ago, Langdock has grown to around 60 employees and €50 million (\$56 million) in revenue.

“It’s actually a pretty great market for new players to get into, because there’s a real openness towards new solutions,” Hofstadt told Reuters.

It’s not all AI

Software is the dominant sector among new startups, accounting for 28% of all newly founded companies. But other areas are also developing, with healthcare firms making up 9% of new startups and food 6%.

Polina Sergeeva launched her healthcare company Menstruflow in

2023, selling a device designed to ease menstrual pain using transcutaneous electrical nerve stimulation (TENS), a technology already widely employed to reduce labour pain but which needed adapting to help with women’s periods.

“When your pain is so bad it destroys your holidays, your plans and everything, then you start thinking, ‘Is there something no one’s ever thought of?’” Sergeeva told Reuters at a founders’ event in Berlin. Menstruflow’s sales rose 300% year-on-year in the first quarter, and Sergeeva’s next goal is to obtain medical certification and enter retail stores.

Recent growth in available funding is providing a tailwind for the boom. Bet-

ween January and September, German startups raised €8 billion in venture capital, more than in all of 2025, according to the German Startup Association’s Startup Monitor.

That propitious environment coupled with a transformative night at the KitKatClub – a legendary fixture of Berlin’s fetish scene – led Paulina Lutz to rethink her career.

“You work with other founders on their ideas and their dreams and you really start to question: why am I not on the other side of this?” said Lutz, who herself had previously earned a six-figure salary working for a venture capital fund. In December 2024, she launched her company Nghty Berlin’s first lingerie collection.

NEW DELHI

Twelve crew members injured after tanker attacked off Oman



REUTERS

Twelve crew members on a Panama-flagged tanker were injured in an attack while crossing the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs said in a statement, with those injured receiving medical treatment in Oman. The Ministry said the tanker, *MT On Peace*, had a 19-member crew, including 17 Indians. AFP

BERLIN

Germany arrests ex-spy chief for ‘passing secrets to foreign powers’



AP

A former German spy chief was arrested on Tuesday on suspicion of passing sensitive information to foreign powers. August Hanning, who ran Germany's BND foreign intelligence agency from 1998 to 2005, is accused of espionage, treason and working for foreign intelligence services, federal prosecutors said. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump approves firing squad execution for Fort Hood shooter



AP

U.S. President Donald Trump has approved the execution by firing squad of Army Major Nidal Malik Hasan for the 2009 shooting rampage at Fort Hood, Texas. Thirteen people were killed and more than 30 injured when Hasan, an Army psychiatrist, walked into a medical building and opened fire with a laser-sighted handgun. AP

NAIROBI

Kenya confirms first Ebola case after traveller from Congo dies



REUTERS

Kenyan authorities on Tuesday confirmed the country's first imported Ebola case from Congo, making Kenya the latest country affected by the fast-moving outbreak. Health Minister Aden Duale said a Kenyan citizen who arrived from Congo via Uganda tested positive for the Ebola virus and died late Monday. AP

Ukraine fires 900 drones overnight at Russia

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian air defences intercepted nearly 900 Ukrainian drones overnight over multiple regions of the country, as well as the occupied Crimean Peninsula and the Sea of Azov, the Defence Ministry in Moscow said on Tuesday.

Unconfirmed media reports said a major fuel depot in the Moscow region was on fire after the attack that killed two people.

Ukrainian officials are now bracing for what President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned is an upcoming “massive” aerial attack by Russia.

“Today, we received updated intelligence on Russia's preparations for a massive strike. We are preparing countermeasures,” Mr. Zelenskyy said.

Meanwhile, the Russian Defence Ministry said its forces overnight struck targets in Ukraine's southern Odesa region on the Black Sea coast with drones, where an ammunition depot was hit.

Houthis ‘hit’ Riyadh airport; Yemen military claims gains

The group denies being pushed back and says it still controlled territory seized during its recent advance along Yemen's Red Sea coast; Riyadh airport is facing temporary closures of its airspace

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

Yemen's Houthis (Ansar Allah) claimed an attack on the Saudi capital's main airport and on Tuesday denied being pushed back by government forces, who have launched a major operation to recapture lost territory.

The Houthi statements come as Yemen's military said it had removed the pro-Iran group from areas around the Bab el-Mandeb strait, a Red Sea chokepoint, and the port city of Mokha.

Claims by both sides in Yemen have been impossible to independently verify, with the situation on the ground moving fast and access for journalists difficult.

Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said the group still held all territory seized last month when they swept through



Pro-government fighters celebrate while riding vehicles in a convoy near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait in Taiz on Tuesday. AFP

coastal areas along the Red Sea oil-and-cargo route.

Houthi fighters “have full control over all their advances on the ground”, he posted on Telegram.

Mr. Saree said they had carried out dozens of strikes in the past few hours targeting government forces in Yemen's Al-Jawf and Marib regions, while also attacking Taiz governorate.

On Monday, the Houthis said they had struck Ri-

yadh airport and a refinery belonging to Saudi state oil giant Aramco.

Loud explosions rattled the Saudi capital on Monday evening. They were followed by another explosion on Tuesday that echoed through northern parts of the city, residents said.

Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport is facing frequent temporary closures of its airspace, according to tracking website

Flightradar24. Saudi authorities have not publicly acknowledged the closures or confirmed any strikes targeting the facility.

But on Tuesday the civil aviation authority said at least three people were wounded in attacks on Jazan and Najran airports near the Yemen border a day earlier.

Saudi Arabia, the main backer of the Yemeni government, has been providing air support for the counter-offensive launched by government forces.

Government forces claimed late Monday that they had achieved “victories on several fronts”. But military sources with the government refrained from confirming Mokha's recapture, only saying they had cut the one supply route to the area.

They also said they expelled the Houthis from several areas in Taiz in the southwest.

Jeffrey Archer, bestselling British novelist, dies at 86

Associated Press
LONDON

Bestselling British author Jeffrey Archer, whose career as a politician was derailed by a perjury conviction, has died. He was 86.

Archer died “suddenly and peacefully” at his home on Monday, a day before the global release of his final novel, *Adam and Eve*, publisher HarperCollins said. Like his bestseller *Kane and Abel*, the new book follows a pair of biblically named characters born on the same day to different social classes.

Both a celebrated author and scandal-plagued politician, Archer's professional life teetered between triumph and turmoil as he wrote his way through a brief prison sentence and returned to the political arena.

His writing career spanned five decades and helped him bounce back from financial ruin following some bad investments. His debut novel, *Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less*, hit the shelves in 1976 and was said to have been in-



Jeffrey Archer climbed the ranks of Britain's Conservative Party under Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher. NAGARA GOPAL

spired by his own experience nearly going bankrupt.

He went on to spend 14 years and five months on Britain's *Sunday Times* bestseller lists and over five years on *The New York Times* bestseller lists, selling 300 million books worldwide, according to HarperCollins.

Political stint

Archer climbed the ranks of Britain's Conservative Party under Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher and was appointed in 1992 to the House of Lords by her successor, Prime Minister John Major.

Archer was cast out of his political party just before he was jailed on perjury charges in 2001.

Archer chronicled his time behind bars in a three-volume series titled *A Prison Diary*. The memoirs – *Hell, Purgatory and Heaven* – shared rare insight into the lives of inmates in British prisons, from the high-security HMP Belmarsh to the North Sea Camp open prison.

Archer is survived by his wife of 60 years, Dame Mary Archer, their two sons, two granddaughters and three grandsons, his publisher said.

Why NASA wants to build a nuclear reactor on the moon

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vasudevan Mukunth



View of Moon limb. ISTOCKPHOTO

NASA wants to install a nuclear reactor near the moon's south pole by 2030. Its planned output, 20 kilowatt (kW), could power a few households on earth. Russia's planned reactor for the International Lunar Research Station (ILRS), led by China, will produce around 10 kW. But the fact that they are nuclear makes them significant. The U.S. and China are pursuing parallel efforts today – in partnership with other countries – to be the first to set up a semi-permanent, and in future permanent, moon base. Such a facility will need electricity for everything from heating and life-support to recharging rover batteries. European scientists are also exploring lunar microreactors.

At most locations on the moon, a fortnight of daylight follows a fortnight of darkness. Near the south pole, where both factions are focusing their activities, promontories and craters create a pastiche of lit and shadowed patches, with temperatures inside some of the latter dipping under a frigid -200 C. But unlike solar panels, a nuclear reactor can produce power even in the dark.

The colder craters preserve water ice, which can quench astronauts' thirst and can also be electro-

lysed to produce hydrogen and oxygen, to power rockets launched from the moon itself. In one 2020 assessment, NASA scientists Julie Kleinhenz and Aaron Paz figured producing 10 tonnes of oxygen this way would require around 68 kW of power. So a 20-kW reactor could be a stepping stone in countries' plans to set up an array of reactors on the moon.

While the moon as a whole is barren, the more ideal locations, with longer periods of sunlight, terrain more suitable to land on, access to craters with water ice, and so on, are highly limited. Research commissioned by NASA has recommended situating nuclear reactors at least 1 km away from humans.

Now, the Outer Space Treaty 1967 says no country may appropriate any part of the moon through occupation or other means. But the Artemis Accords, to which the U.S. and its allies vis-à-vis the moon are signatories, envisage 'safety zones' to prevent harmful interference. Put differently, a state does not have to stake territory

on the moon to limit access to others: it can simply plonk a nuclear reactor there and appeal to the need for legitimate safety requirements.

The Accords say these zones must be temporary and respect free access – but a country or a bloc operating a cluster of reactors, landing pads, mines, and habitats could nevertheless gain a controlling advantage. For the appeal of this idea, however, both Artemis and ILRS face breathtaking technical hurdles. Shielding a nuclear reactor on the moon demands either launching the components to ensure its safe operation or producing them on the moon with lunar resources. Distanting a reactor from a base demands deployment machines and power cables. The reactor core will also have to be launched unirradiated and, once online, space agencies will have to find ways to absorb and store all the heat – or radiate waste heat away from large surfaces kept free of moon dust. If a reactor fails on the moon, it could contaminate the same few places astronauts would like to be at.

While nuclear power could prove indispensable to a mature economy centred on the moon, no country possesses that economy today even as governments are being tempted to install reactors before their opponents – a danger in itself.

Seeking solutions



Tens of thousands march protesting the housing situation in Spain, just hours after Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez announced an early general election, in Barcelona, Spain, on Monday. The government on Tuesday approved urgent measures to tackle the housing crisis. AP

Hundreds held in French school students' protests

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Mass protests over decrepit conditions at France's high schools descended into sporadic violence on Tuesday, leading to nearly 500 arrests and prompting President Emmanuel Macron to call an emergency meeting.

The protests started in late September with students blocking entrances to hundreds of high schools over complaints of dilapidated facilities and

teacher shortages.

U.S. President Donald Trump weighed in on Tuesday to blame the unrest in France on “mass migration” and Islam, as he pushed his global right-wing narrative ahead of tough midterm elections at home.

In France, parents, teachers and union workers joined the high school students' movement in the capital Paris and other cities.

The Interior Ministry said 256,000 people prot-



French riot police charge protesters during a demonstration by high school and university students in Paris, France, on Tuesday. REUTERS

ested nationwide, while union organisers put the figure at 450,000.

Mr. Macron was expected to meet top officials late Tuesday, including Interior

Mali Army says it has entered key city of Kidal

Agence France-Presse
BAMAKO

The Malian army says it has entered the strategic northern city of Kidal, which was captured around five months ago by Tuareg separatists who announced their withdrawal earlier on Tuesday as the military advanced.

In its statement, the Tuareg separatist Azawad Liberation Front (FLA) said that it “temporarily” left Kidal “due to the disproportionate use of aerial assets by Russian mercenaries from Africa Corps and the terrorist forces of the Bamako military junta” in order to “preserve human lives”.

Minister Laurent Nunez and Education Minister Edouard Geffray, in response to the unrest, a government source said.

At least 488 people were arrested and 43 members of the security forces were wounded on Tuesday, the Interior Ministry announced.

Rights groups, unions and the students have accused authorities of using disproportionate force.

Police said “300 hostile individuals” attempted to confront officers.



The new intercontinental missile is fired from a submarine off the coast of Finistere, western France, on Tuesday. AFP

France tests latest nuclear missile amid Russia scare

Reuters
PARIS

France's Defence Ministry said on Tuesday it had conducted the first test launch of its latest-generation M51.3 submarine-launched ballistic missile, underscoring its nuclear deterrent amid heightened tensions with Russia.

The M51.3 missile, which was not equipped with a nuclear warhead, was launched off the coast of Brittany as part of an operation to certify the nuclear-submarine Le Vigilant's ability to deploy the weapon following a major maintenance overhaul, the Ministry said. It added the launch was conducted without a payload and in strict compliance with international obligations.

While the announcement made no mention of Russia, the test comes after President Vladimir Putin warned the West last week not to escalate a standoff over Ukraine by threatening the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad, which is wedged between EU members Poland and Lithuania and which Moscow has made clear it would defend with nuclear weapons if necessary.

NATO has said none of its "exercises or activities pose a threat to the territory of the Russian Federation". Mr. Putin also said Russia had no plans to attack any European country and wanted to coexist peacefully.

"Today we are stronger. The message has been sent loud and clear for wherever it must be received," President Emmanuel Macron said in a video on X showing him watching the launch.

Mr. Macron said in March France would expand its nuclear arsenal and launched an initiative offering European partners joint exercises, possible short-term deployment of nuclear-capable assets on allied territory and deeper consultation.

Cornell sexual assault case resurfaces, casting doubts on campus proceedings

As investigation is reopened, the focus is on what evidence was provided to prosecutors since district attorney maintains student's statement did not establish criminal offence; her lawyers point out she had described her incapacitation and gang rape in interviews conducted by CUPD in Nov. 2024

NEWS ANALYSIS

Rizmi Lia M.

The 2024 alleged Cornell University sexual assault case in the U.S. has resurfaced now after the woman involved filed a civil lawsuit in September 2026 against the university, the fraternity and the seven accused men. The incident involved seven members of Cornell University's Chi Phi fraternity.

The university's independent student newspaper, *The Cornell Daily Sun*, broke the story on September 18, publishing reports that brought the university's Title IX disciplinary proceedings and the way university handled the case to public attention. Title IX proceedings are initiated by federally funded educational institutions to resolve allegations of sex-based discrimination, sexual harassment, and sexual assault.

Last month, the local district attorney announced that the investigation would be reopened. New York Governor Kathy Hochul appointed Attorney General Letitia James as special prosecutor.

No charges initially

The alleged incident took place at the Chi Phi fraternity house in Ithaca, New York, on the night of Oc-

tober 19, 2024. The woman, referred to as Jane Doe in legal documents, was a 20-year-old Cornell student at that time. In her complaint, she said she had been heavily intoxicated and incapacitated and could not have given consent to any sexual activity.

In November 2024, Doe reported the incident to the Cornell University Police Department (CUPD), and Cornell subsequently started its own Title IX investigation.

The university also referred for a criminal investigation to the Tompkins County District Attorney's Office. But that initial investigation resulted in no charges.

Matthew Van Houten, the Tompkins County District Attorney, maintained that the statement provided to his office did not establish a criminal offence under New York law. In a statement, the DA's office said "Jane Doe's sworn statement in November of 2024 did not allege that she was drugged against her will or gang-raped. On the contrary, Jane Doe's statement described her participation in drug use and sexual conduct as voluntary, conscious, and consensual. My office obviously did not and could not have based our November 2024 decision on the allegations in a civil lawsuit that would not be filed until nearly two years later."



Demonstrators attend a protest against the university's handling of the gang rape allegations at the campus on Monday. AP

However, Doe's lawyers disputed that and pointed to interviews conducted by CUPD in November 2024, in which Doe described her alleged incapacitation and said she had been raped.

That raised several questions about what information CUPD provided to the district attorney's office. *The Cornell Daily Sun* reported that "Cornell released an FAQ page addressing the University's response to the alleged 2024 Chi Phi gang rape in a Tuesday evening email sent to the Cornell community. The page contradicts a claim made by the Tompkins County District Attorney."

What evidence was actually provided to prosecutors is now one of the main issues being examined as the criminal investigation is being reopened.

Cornell conducted its

own disciplinary process Title IX in January 2025, separate from the criminal investigation. The university stated that "The university's Title IX investigation was conducted over several months and included hearings where a panel of trained faculty and staff heard evidence over multiple days. The complainant and respondents had the opportunity to testify and present evidence in the university's investigation. At its conclusion, the hearing panel issued a range of sanctions, which included expulsions and suspensions from Cornell."

Of the seven accused men, two were expelled and two received suspensions lasting multiple semesters. Another student, who had graduated before the process was completed, was barred from entering campus for three years.

In two other cases, the

students were found not responsible for sexual misconduct, although they still received various administrative and educational sanctions, including to write "reflection papers". Cornell also permanently revoked its recognition of the Chi Phi chapter and closed it.

The university's disciplinary measures, particularly references to written assignments given to some of the accused students gained public outrage. Cornell has strongly denied that students accused of sexual assault were simply told to write essays as punishment. The university said in a statement that the written assignments were part of broader educational sanctions and were not the "sole consequence" in cases where more serious disciplinary measures had also been imposed.

The case continued to receive wider attention among Cornell students and around the world as required from timely reports by *The Cornell Daily Sun*. That attention led to protests, statements from alumni and calls from the Cornell Student Assembly for greater transparency and changes to the university's policies on sexual violence.

Cornell has emphasised that its process was focused on determining whether its own policies had been violated, while

the district attorney's office was responsible for deciding whether there was sufficient evidence to pursue criminal charges.

What happens next?

The criminal investigation has now been reopened. District Attorney Van Houten's role in the case was replaced after Governor Hochul appointed New York Attorney General Letitia James as special prosecutor. Ms. James will oversee the criminal investigation and determine whether the evidence supports bringing criminal charges.

Meanwhile, Doe's civil lawsuit is still ongoing. It names Cornell, the fraternity organisations and the seven men as defendants and lays out her allegations concerning the assault and Cornell's handling of her complaint.

Cornell has said it will cooperate with the reopened criminal investigation and support an independent review of how it handled the case. The university reiterates in its statement that "We will continue to examine and strengthen our policies to ensure we are doing all we can to foster a culture where sexual misconduct is never tolerated, those who come forward are supported, and individuals found responsible through our processes are held accountable".

Satellite images show attack aircraft, military vehicles at China-Laos base

Reuters
HONG KONG/BANGKOK

Light attack aircraft and military vehicles have arrived at the new China-Laos joint training facility announced last Tuesday, according to satellite images reviewed by Reuters.

The images, taken by commercial satellite provider Vantor, show what security analysts believe are eight K-8 light attack jets and more than two dozen support vehicles on a runway that is still being built – China's latest expansion of its overseas military presence.

Taken on September 30, the day after China's Defence Ministry announced



A satellite image shows what analysts believe are Y-8 attack fighters at the base in Ban Keun, Laos, on September 30. REUTERS

it had set up the facility at Ban Keun outside the capital Vientiane, the images show extensive construction around the runway.

The swift development of the new facility is being closely watched by region-

al military attaches and security scholars, some of whom say it potentially marks China's first fully fledged overseas military base in Southeast Asia.

Despite more than 20 years of intense military

modernisation, China is widely perceived to lack a strong network of overseas facilities beyond the South China Sea, port access in Ream, Cambodia and a logistics base in Djibouti.

Rachel Vandenbrink, a senior analyst at the Australian Strategic Policy Institute, said the selection of Ban Keun for a facility that the People's Liberation Army could access "is likely more about a target of opportunity than filling an obvious operational need."

The Chinese Defence Ministry did not immediately respond to Reuters' request for comment. The Lao Foreign Ministry did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

Leave me alone!



Time to relax: People watch a southern elephant seal resting on the shore of Copacabana Beach in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, on Tuesday. AFP

Much of the world sees tragedy in Gaza, but many Israelis see only a threat

Associated Press
SDEROT

One by one, Israelis peered through the tourist-style binoculars at the shattered Gaza town of Beit Hanoun, a distance of several football fields away, where buildings tilted in the rubble like broken teeth. The only noticeable movement was dust kicked up by Israel's military.

The Israelis squinted for a few moments and gestured others over. The lookout is a rare place where they can confront the Palestinian territory firsthand, and some celebrate its devastation.

An Israeli documentary released this year included one onlooker exclaiming, "Wow, destroyed beautifully." The Associated Press heard similar sentiments there.

On October 7, 2023, Hamas-led militants killed some 1,200 people in southern Israel and abducted 251 others, leading to a devastating war and, eventually, a fragile ceasefire.

Three years on, a visit to the communities attacked that day made clear: It's too soon for many residents to see the Palestinians next door as anything other than a threat.

One resident, Deganit Bar Hay, said she still could not barbecue because the smell of burnt flesh – "the smell of hell" – is a trigger.

Globally, there is shock and condemnation over how Israel has conducted the war, and how Gaza remains in ruins and cut off from the world a year since the ceasefire.

Over 74,000 Palestinians have been killed, ac-

cording to Gaza's Health Ministry, and the vast majority of its two million residents live in rat-infested tent camps or among the debris.

No empathy

But empathy for them is still unthinkable for many in Israel, with memories raw. Israeli media report little on the Palestinians of Gaza, and Israelis rarely if ever hear their voices unless they seek them out.

A new Israeli documentary, "NAZA", in which military insiders describe what they said was the systemic killing of Palestinian civilians in Gaza, has sparked outrage at the filmmakers, not the government.

"We are post-traumatic, all of us," said Ziporah Livneh, outside a cafe catering to tour groups and sol-



A memorial for October 7, 2023 attack victims stands beside a sidewalk in Sderot, southern Israel, on October 3. AP

diers a short drive from Gaza. Much of her family died in the Holocaust, and she came to Israel at the age of two.

Now, she said, the answer for Gaza is to keep believing in people's humanity but respond strongly to acts of evil. A society and a country can't be built on revenge, but for the world

to think "we can be Mother Teresa, it is a hypocrisy".

Many Israelis are still turned inward. They say their story is not being heard or understood. They say Palestinians in Gaza receive more attention, even as Israel's government still prevents journalists from entering the territory except under rare, highly

managed visits – and very few Palestinians can leave.

From the day the war began, Israeli news and hearts were focused on the dead and the hostages taken into Gaza. Cross-border contact had been severely limited since Hamas seized power in 2007. Then, on October 7, militants ripped the fence apart.

This is the first anniversary since the attack that all remaining hostages are out of Gaza, alive or dead.

There is rebuilding in the Israeli communities where militants went home to home, burning and shooting. There is also the insistence on keeping October 7 memories alive, with hope that the outside world will come to understand how Israel's sense of security was smashed.

"I know many people

around the globe don't understand us," said Mor Izreal, director of an October 7 virtual reality exhibit in the border city of Sderot. She said over 10,000 people have visited since it opened a year and a half ago, most from overseas. Reactions range from sadness to rage to connectedness, she said.

This year, for the first time since the attack, there is also an election, a momentous and angry one.

Divisive government

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government is deeply divisive. Many Israelis accuse him of failing to prevent the October 7 attack and not securing the hostages' release sooner, before many of them were killed. He is accused of corruption and threatening democratic institutions.

But there has been little criticism of how his government has treated the Palestinians in Gaza, where Israel's military now controls over 60% of the territory, squeezing them into an ever-smaller space.

Next to a bullet-pocked rocket shelter outside Sderot, a man held a banner calling for an official inquiry into the security failures surrounding the attack. Mr. Netanyahu has long resisted one.

"Death to Arabs" is written inside a rocket shelter across from the Sderot police station that was besieged and then destroyed. "Hamas is still in Gaza" is scrawled on a guardrail on the highway where bodies spilled from vehicles on Oct. 7. "Make Gaza Jewish Again" is on a banner in a public square in Jerusalem's Old City.

Novak Djokovic won his seventh China Open title after Alex de Minaur retired with a groin injury during the final in Beijing on Tuesday, de Minaur left the court for a medical timeout after losing the first-set tie-breaker, but played on with his left thigh bandaged. However, he had to stop after winning the first game of the second set, leaving him trailing 6-7(3), 1-0. Sixth-ranked Djokovic's win continued his unbeaten record at the tournament with 34 straight victories.

India, Qatar and South Africa were confirmed on Tuesday among the seven countries interested in hosting the 2036 Summer Olympics. Germany, Hungary, Türkiye and South Korea make up the rest of the current list issued by the International Olympic Committee (IOC). Other countries have until October 31 to declare an interest. In March 2027, the IOC Executive Board will draw up a shortlist of the interested parties, who will then enter dialogue with the Olympic body. India is most likely to host it in Ahmedabad, the venue for the 2030 Commonwealth Games.

Aditya Mehta hopes to deliver a special gift for his little one

"I definitely feel the game is there, and I'd love to win this time".

Ganguly named Capitals head coach

Ganguly, who is also president of the Cricket Association of Bengal, has been JSW Sports' Director of Cricket since 2024.

After County stint, Sai Kishore aims to win it all with Tamil Nadu

Indians get pride of place for WTT Feeder

Prabodh knocks out Balsekar



The Chennai GM took the chess world by storm in her maiden Olympiad appearance, winning individual gold on the reserve board and helping India bag the team bronze.

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